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Centre approves 1,647 crore for 28 Delhi infrastructure projects



NATION: Pg 4

ISRO successfully carries out tests of Gaganyaan crew module systems



FILM: Pg 12

'You can't sit here and crack roles there'

HORMUZ AT THE HEART OF A DANGEROUS NEW US-IRAN SHOWDOWN

Arab states rocked by Iranian retaliation after massive US assault on 140 targets

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: The United States attacked Iran early Sunday over an Iranian strike on a container ship in the Strait of Hormuz that set it ablaze and left one crew member missing. Iran responded with attacks on several countries in the Middle East, including Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan and Oman — the country on the other side of the strait, which Tehran wants to join it in managing traffic there.

The fighting raised new questions about the interim deal Iran and the US reached on June 17, beginning a 60-day period aimed at reaching a permanent end to the war. The mid-way point of that period comes within the week.

The strait, a key route for the global supply of oil and natural



FILE PHOTO

gas, has become the key sticking point in negotiations, and fighting over the past week has left negotiations in danger of collapse.

The US military's Central Command said it hit some 140 targets, including missile and drone launch sites, ammunition dumps, communication equip-

ment and other sites. It said the attacks, heavier than in recent days, would weaken Iran's ability to threaten shipping.

Continued on P4

HIGHLIGHTS

- » US struck over 140 Iranian targets after container ship attack in Strait of Hormuz
- » Iran retaliated with attacks targeting Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan and Oman
- » Fighting threatens June 17 interim US-Iran deal aimed at ending the war
- » Strait of Hormuz dispute remains the biggest obstacle to peace talks
- » Trump said US strikes would weaken Iran's ability to threaten shipping
- » Iran declared the strait closed until calm returns; US insisted it remains open

India condemns attack on ship off Oman coast; 10 rescued, 1 Indian missing

NEW DELHI: India on Sunday condemned the attack on the Cyprus-flagged commercial vessel GFS Galaxy off the coast of Oman, in which one of the 11 Indian crew members remains missing. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said 10 Indian nationals have been rescued and the search for the missing crew member is continuing.

"We condemn the attack on the commercial vessel GFS Galaxy off the coast of Oman," the MEA said, add-

ing that the Indian Embassy in Oman is closely coordinating with Omani authorities involved in the search and rescue operation. It also thanked Oman for its support.

The attack came as fresh hostilities unfolded between Iran and the United States in West Asia. The US Central Command alleged that the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps attacked the container ship while it was passing through the Strait of Hormuz. It said a civilian crew

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EC makes parents' SIR details mandatory for new voter enrolment

Declaration reduces document requirements



FILE PHOTO

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission has made it mandatory for new voter applicants to provide their parents' Special Intensive Revision (SIR) details while applying for inclusion in the electoral rolls, extending a requirement that was earlier linked to existing voters not covered in previous SIR exercises.

According to Election Commission officials, new applicants filing Form 6 must submit a declaration containing their parents' SIR details. The requirement was first introduced during the Bihar Special Intensive Revision launched in June last year, where new voters were asked to file the declaration along with Form 6.

CLOSER LOOK

- » New voters cannot complete Form 6 without SIR declaration
- » Parents' SIR declaration added through EC instructions
- » Form 6 itself has not been amended, EC says

"Daily SIR bulletins of Bihar showed the form filled along with the declarations," an EC functionary said.

Officials clarified that the declaration was introduced through administrative instructions and that Form 6 itself has not been formally amended.

"It helps in mapping electors and

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Panel proposes suspension not removal of PM and CMs detained for over 30 days

Opposition had called the Bill a tool to destabilise rival governments

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary committee has recommended changes to the proposed 130th Constitution Amendment Bill, suggesting that the prime minister, Union ministers and chief ministers be suspended rather than permanently removed from office if they remain in judicial detention for 30 consecutive days on charges involving serious criminal offences.

The Joint Committee of Parliament, which examined the Bill introduced last August, also proposed an automatic reversal clause under which the suspension would end if the individual is acquitted or if the prosecution fails to move forward within a specified period.

The Bill, in its current form, provides for the automatic removal of the prime minister, ministers or chief ministers on the 31st day of detention if they do not resign voluntarily. It was introduced with the stated objective of ensuring that governments are not run from jail.

The legislation faced strong criticism from opposition parties, which described it as a mechanism to destabilise governments led by them. Most opposition parties chose not to participate in the parliamentary committee examining the Bill.

TAKEAWAYS

- » Suspension should end automatically if accused is acquitted, panel says
- » Committee seeks reinstatement safeguard for ministers cleared by courts
- » Serious offences defined as crimes punishable with five years or more.

In a report expected to be adopted this week, the panel made two specific and three general recommendations. It proposed replacing the word "removal" with "suspension", saying, "Ministers facing specified criminal charges should be suspended, not permanently removed, pending the outcome of legal proceedings."

The committee also defined "serious criminal offences" as offences punishable with imprisonment of five years or more. It recommended that the proposed law include a separate schedule listing such offences to clearly identify cases that would trigger suspension.

To protect those later found innocent, the panel said the suspension should automatically end if the person is acquitted or if the prosecution does not proceed within a specified period,

Continued on P4

Monsoon activity subdued in large parts of India

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Southwest Monsoon activity remained subdued across large parts of India on Sunday, with heavy rainfall largely limited to Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, West Bengal and the northeastern states, while the India Meteorological Department

(IMD) warned that intense showers would continue in some regions over the next few days. The weather office forecast isolated heavy to very heavy rainfall over northeast India, West Bengal and Bihar during the next two to three days, and isolated heavy rainfall over eastern Uttar Pradesh over the next

Continued on P4



Former Qatari Emir Sheikh Hamad passes away; India declares one-day mourning

PM Modi describes him as 'true friend'

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: India will observe a one-day national mourning on Monday following the death of former Emir of Qatar Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al-Thani, who died on Sunday at the age of 74. Prime Minister Narendra Modi paid tribute to the late leader, describing him as a "visionary leader" who guided Qatar's transformation and remained a close friend of India.

In a message on social media, Modi said, "We feel profound sadness at the death of the Father Emir of the State of Qatar Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani." He added, "He was a visionary leader who guided Qatar to great levels of development and prosperity. We also remember him as a true friend whom I had the hon-

our of meeting during my last visit to Qatar in February 2024."

The prime minister also conveyed his "sincerest condolences" to Qatar's Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al-Thani, the royal family and the people of Qatar.

The Ministry of External Affairs said the national flag would be flown at half-mast across India on all buildings where it is regularly displayed, and there would be no official entertainment during the day of mourning. It also announced that Parliamentary and Minority Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju is expected to visit Qatar shortly to convey India's condolences.

Known as the Father Emir of Qatar, Sheikh Hamad ruled the Gulf nation from 1995 to 2013. He is widely credited

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A tunnel and a highway could redraw the map of opportunity

Road projects worth Rs 14,115 cr cleared for Delhi, UP

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A daily drive from Dwarka to South Delhi can often turn into an exercise in patience. A trip between Kanpur and Kabrai can take more than three hours. The Union Cabinet's approval of two major road projects worth nearly Rs 14,115 crore aims to change that, while opening new opportunities for businesses, real estate and regional development.

The Centre has cleared an 8.1 km six-lane tunnel connecting the Dwarka Expressway with Nelson Mandela Marg in South Delhi and a 117.7 km access-controlled green-field highway between Kanpur and Kabrai in Uttar Pradesh. Together, the projects are designed to improve connectivity, reduce travel time and

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Delhi gets an 8.1 km six-lane tunnel
- » Uttar Pradesh gets a 117.7 km greenfield highway
- » Delhi tunnel costs Rs

6,969.67 crore

» UP highway costs Rs 7,145.14 crore

» Tunnel links Dwarka Expressway with Nelson Mandela Marg

» Highway joins the Bhopal-Kanpur Economic Corridor

strengthen logistics in two fast-growing regions.

For Delhi-NCR, the tunnel could make daily commuting more predictable. Approved at an estimated cost of Rs 6,969.67 crore under the Hybrid Annuity Model, it will provide uninterrupted connectivity between Dwarka Expressway, Indira Gandhi International Airport, Dwarka, Vasant Kunj and South Delhi. It will also link with the upcoming AIIMS

Mahipalpur elevated corridor, improving access towards Noida, Ghaziabad and East Delhi.

The government estimates that construction of the tunnel will generate nearly 7.54 lakh man-days of direct employment and around 9.8 lakh man-days of indirect employment, adding an economic boost even before the project becomes operational.

Continued on P4

India buys record EUR 4.5 billion of Russian crude oil in June

NEW DELHI: India's imports of Russian crude reached a record in June, rising 34 per cent from May to EUR 4.5 billion, according to the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA). Russian crude made up 83 per cent of India's EUR 5.5 billion fossil fuel imports, keeping India the second-largest buyer after China. Higher purchases by Reliance's Jamnagar, Indian Oil's Paradip, BPCL's Kochi and Naya's Vadinar refineries helped lift Russia's crude export volumes 14 per cent, although export revenues fell 8 per cent due to lower prices.

See P9



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TWISHA DEATH CASE

AIIMS Delhi’s final report to CBI confirms skin tissue on gym belt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The final forensic report of AIIMS Delhi in the Twisha Sharma death case has concluded that a gymnastics belt could have been used in the incident as it found the presence of the victim's skin tissue on it, sources said.

The AIIMS Delhi medical board, which conducted a court-ordered second post-mortem on Twisha, submitted the report to the CBI on July 10, confirming that the alleged ligature material – the gymnastics belt with a metal ring at the end – matched the injury pattern on the victim's neck, they said.

Former model-actress Twisha, who got married to lawyer Samarth Singh last December, was found hanging at her marital home in Bhopal on May 12.

The sources said the central probe agency is studying the report by AIIMS Delhi, which conducted a second post-mortem on Twisha on May 24, after the first autopsy at AIIMS Bhopal proved inconclusive as the alleged ligature material was not produced before its medical board.

Police seized the belt later and submitted it for inspection



to the second medical board led by experts from AIIMS Delhi, they said.

The five-member board handed over its 11-page report to the CBI in a sealed cover, in compliance with a Madhya Pradesh High Court order.

A compliance report has also been sent to the registrar general of the high court, the sources said.

According to sources familiar with the findings, laboratory and histopathological examinations detected skin tissue on the belt, which corresponded with the ligature mark and injury pattern observed during the second post-mortem.

Dr Sudhir Gupta, Head of Forensic Medicine at AIIMS Delhi, said the board undertook an exhaustive scientific evaluation before arriving at its conclusion.

“The medical board deliberated very minutely on the case from all possible angles, taking into consideration all available national and international journals for almost one month before giving a detailed opinion with scientific justification. It is a crystal-clear opinion for the CBI and for the judiciary in the interest of truth and justice,” Gupta said.

He, however, declined to elaborate further, saying

CLOSER LOOK

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» According to sources familiar with the findings, laboratory and histopathological examinations detected skin tissue on the belt, which corresponded with the ligature mark and injury pattern observed during the second post-mortem

ing the report had been submitted to the CBI in a sealed cover in compliance with the court's directions.

According to the forwarding letter, the report was handed over to the CBI investigating officer, while the videography of the second post-mortem remained in the custody of the investigating agency. The report is expected to form a crucial piece of scientific evidence in the agency's probe, the sources said.

According to the FIR lodged in the case, Samarth took Twisha to AIIMS Bhopal, where he claimed that she had hung herself at home at 10.20

pm on May 12.

However, a doctor at AIIMS Bhopal told police later that Twisha was brought dead to the hospital after which a medico-legal case was registered, the FIR said. In their statements given to police at the time of filing the FIR, Twisha's family members said she spoke to her mother at 9.41 pm on May 12.

During the call, Samarth could be heard shouting before the phone was cut abruptly, the family alleged.

After repeated calls went unanswered, Twisha's mother-in-law Giribala Singh, a retired judge, picked up the phone and told Twisha's sister-in-law that “she is no more”, before cutting the call, the FIR alleged.

The first post-mortem report concluded that the death was caused by “antemortem hanging by ligature” and found “multiple antemortem injuries”.

Alleging lapses in the initial probe and post-mortem, Twisha's family approached the Madhya Pradesh High Court, which ordered a second autopsy by AIIMS Delhi and transferred the case to the CBI. They also alleged dowry harassment, mental torture and domestic violence.

Engineer fatally stabs girlfriend, kills self by jumping before train

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: An AI engineer allegedly stabbed his girlfriend to death inside his PG accommodation in Gurugram before committing suicide by jumping in front of a train, police said on Sunday.

The deceased were identified as Shreshth Malik (25), a resident of Bhilai in Chhattisgarh, and his girlfriend Ishara Ayubi (25), from Uttar Pradesh's Sitapur. Both worked for the same private company in Gurugram. Malik lived in a PG accommodation in Sector 55. The incident came to light after Ayubi's family approached the Sector-56 police station on Saturday when they were unable to contact her.

Acting on the complaint, police traced her mobile phone location to Malik's PG in Sector 55. After questioning neighbours, who said they were unaware of any incident, police had the room opened.

Inside, they found Ayubi's body lying in a pool of blood, with blood splattered everywhere. Preliminary investigation indicated that she had been stabbed to death. A forensic science laboratory (FSL) team examined the scene and collected evidence.

During the investigation,



police learnt that a man's body had already been recovered from the railway tracks near Garhi railway station by the Government Railway Police (GRP). His body had been severed into two pieces after being hit by a train. The deceased was identified as Malik through the mobile phone recovered from him, linking the two cases, police said. Preliminary investigation revealed that Ayubi had started living with Malik in the PG accommodation three days before the incident.

“We are investigating every aspect of the case. The nature of the relationship between the two individuals and the reasons behind the incident would only be revealed once the investigation is complete.

Police are examining the accused's mobile phones, call records, chats and other technical evidence. An FIR for murder has been registered, and further investigation is underway.

Delhi Police nab final accused in Shahbad Café killing

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested the fourth and final accused in the murder of a young man following a violent clash over changing songs at a café in Shahbad Daulatpur.

Police were alerted to the incident through a PCR call received at Shahbad Dairy Police Station. The latest arrest is Amit Kumar alias Baba (18), a resident of Mangolpuri.

The case has been registered under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Shahbad Dairy Police Station. Police said a knife allegedly used in the murder has also been recovered during the investigation.

The incident occurred during the intervening night of June 17 and 18, when Kali Charan alias Sunny and his friends were at a café in Shahbad Daulatpur.

According to police, an argument broke out with a group of youths over changing songs. After allegedly threatening the victims, the group left the café but returned shortly afterwards with more associates armed with knives.

The assailants allegedly entered the room where the victims were having food and attacked Kali Charan and one of his friends, inflicting multiple stab injuries to their heads, hands, waist and abdomen before fleeing the spot.

Both injured men were rushed to BSA Hospital, where Kali Charan later succumbed to his injuries.

Police said a special investigation team examined eyewitness accounts, analysed technical evidence, gathered local intelligence and conducted multiple raids.

Two accused were initially arrested with the assistance of the Crime Branch, while the remaining two, including the final suspect, were apprehended by the local police team.

Further investigation is underway to recover additional evidence and strengthen the prosecution's case.

Labourer dies after roof projection gives way; building sealed

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 55-year-old labourer died after falling from the fourth floor of an under-construction building when a roof projection collapsed in West Delhi's Tilak Nagar, prompting police to register a case against the building owner and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to order the premises sealed.

According to police, a PCR call reporting the incident was received at Tilak Nagar Police Station at around 3 pm on July 10.

A police team rushed to Gali No. 3, Krishna Puri, where they learnt that the injured labourer, identified as Md. Bhola, had already been taken to Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital. He was later referred to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash Hospital, where doctors declared him dead. Preliminary investigation revealed that Bhola was carrying out construction work on the fourth floor when a portion of the roof projection (chajja) suddenly collapsed, causing him to fall to the ground and sustain fatal injuries.



“He was referred to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash Hosp, where doctors declared him dead”

The Crime Team inspected the site and documented the scene as part of the investigation. Based on the statement of a co-worker, an FIR was registered against the building owner, Om Prakash Kataria, a resident of the same address, under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Police said details of the incident, along with photographs of the under-construction building, were shared with the MCD, following which the civic body ordered the premises to be sealed.

Man held for gunpoint robbery in Gandhi Ngr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested a 22-year-old man in connection with a gunpoint robbery in East Delhi's Gandhi Nagar and recovered a newly purchased motorcycle allegedly bought using the stolen money.

According to police, the robbery took place on July 10 after Ashish Sarin, a collection executive with S.D. Enterprise, had collected around Rs 16.5 lakh from various business establishments. At about 4 pm, after reaching outside his office and unloading the cash bag from his Honda Activa, two armed men arrived on a scooter. One was wearing a helmet while the other had covered his face with a mask. They allegedly threatened Sarin at gunpoint, snatched the bag containing the cash, his Aadhaar card and bank passbook, and fled.

Following the registration of an FIR under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Gandhi Nagar Police Station, a



Police recovered Rs 2.5 lakh in cash

special investigation team launched a probe. Although the suspects had removed the scooter's rear number plate, investigators identified the vehicle through CCTV footage capturing its front registration number and technical surveillance.

Police arrested Alpaid (22), who allegedly revealed that co-accused Ashu planned the robbery and supplied firearms, while Krishna also took part. Police recovered Rs 2.5 lakh, the scooter used in the crime and a motorcycle allegedly bought with the stolen money.

Three shooters linked to Harry Boxer gang nabbed, conspiracy to kill businessman foiled: Delhi Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police on Sunday said they have arrested three alleged shooters linked to the Harry Boxer gang and foiled a conspiracy to extort businessmen and carry out targeted killings across Delhi-NCR, an official said on Sunday.

Police recovered three illegal pistols, including a 9-mm calibre and a Beretta, along with 26 live cartridges, he said.

Police said the operation was jointly carried out by the Special Staff of Rohini district and North Rohini police station following months of investigation into an extortion case registered earlier this year.

According to police, a businessman lodged a complaint on March 8 alleging he had received repeated calls and messages from foreign-based phone numbers between March 6 and 8.

The caller identified himself as Randeep Malik, and claiming was associated with the Harry Boxer gang, demanded an amount of Rs 1 crore and threatened to kill the complainant if the money was not paid.

Based on the complaint, an FIR was registered. “During the probe, police found that the gang had expanded its operations beyond extortion and was conducting reconnaissance of businessmen's residences across Delhi-NCR for targeted killings.

Similar extortion calls were allegedly made to several jewellers in the Karol Bagh area,” a senior police officer said.

The threat escalated on July 4 when the complainant again received a call along with photographs and videos of his residence. The caller identified himself as Harry Boxer and claimed that surveillance of the house had already been completed.

He allegedly threatened to kill either the businessman or

one of his family members if the extortion demand was not met. Police said the revelation that the complainant's house had already been surveyed prompted an intensive investigation involving technical surveillance, human intelligence, CCTV analysis covering the previous 15 days, digital forensic examination and scrutiny of encrypted communications.

The investigation led police to Shiv Govind, whose movements matched technical inputs gathered during the probe. He was apprehended from Srinivaspuri in Delhi.

Examination of his mobile phone revealed photographs

and videos of the complainant's residence as well as photographs of jewellery establishments in Karol Bagh. Police said the material had been transmitted to gang handlers through an encrypted messaging application.

“Based on sustained interrogation and technical analysis, police identified two more alleged gang members -- Abhinav alias Akash Singh, and Vivek. Police recovered three pistols, 26 cartridges, a motorcycle and mobile phones containing incriminating evidence. Investigation is underway to trace the gang's handlers, financiers and overseas operatives.

Two arrested for raping & killing seven-year-old girl in Ghaziabad

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: An 18-year-old labourer and a co-worker were arrested and sent to the jail on Sunday after being accused of luring a seven-year-old girl into an under-construction mall in Ghaziabad's Raj Nagar Extension area, brutally raping and murdering her, and dumping her body three floors down in the basement of a mall, police said.

The victim was playing near the construction site with her brothers on Friday evening when she went missing around 7.30 pm. Her family searched the area but could not find her. Her body was discovered in the mall basement and police were informed, after which a team rushed to the scene.

According to police, the two accused — Vinay Kumar (18), and Sahibuddin (22), both from Bihar — had been working at the mall for about two-and-a-half months. Police said Vinay had been friendly with the children, often giving them chips and toffees, and had paid particular attention to the girl in the weeks before the attack.

CCTV footage helped reconstruct the final hours. “When we scanned CCTV footage, we found that the two accused entered the mall with the girl through the main gate around 7.40 pm. A couple of hours later, they came out — without her,” said Dhaawal Jaiswal, DCP (City and Trans-Hindon). Police said the sequence of events was calculated and brutal. After luring the girl inside on the pretext of buying snacks and a soft drink, the men allegedly took her to the third floor, beat her, raped her and then killed her.

“Vinay picked up an iron rod and struck her head repeatedly. Once they were certain she was dead, both men carried her to a nearby staircase and dropped her body into the basement through a shaft,” a senior officer said.

An autopsy found multiple injury marks on the body with fractures on her leg.

Police said both accused were intoxicated at the time of the crime and had routinely drunk together since arriving from Bihar. The under-construction mall had no guard at the entrance, which police said allowed the accused to enter unnoticed.

Acting on a complaint by the girl's father, an FIR was registered at Nandgram Police Station under relevant sections of the BNS, including gang rape, kidnapping, murder and causing death, and provisions of the POCSO Act. Both accused were produced in court on Sunday and remanded to judicial custody.

NDMC’s mechanised sanitation works in CP, falters in Kaka Ngr

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council's (NDMC) push towards mechanised sanitation has produced contrasting results across the Capital, with field visits revealing a clear divide between the implementation of battery-operated gobbler machines in Connaught Place and the earlier mechanised cleaning initiative in Kaka Nagar.

In Kaka Nagar, NDMC had projected the colony as Delhi's first fully mechanised cleaning model. However, sanitation workers claimed manual sweeping continued to be the primary mode of cleaning. Workers alleged that the machines were slow, unsuitable for uneven roads and tiled surfaces, and often required manual cleaning before they could be operated.

A follow-up visit to Con-



naught Place, however, presented a different picture. Sanitation worker Sameer, who has been operating the battery-powered gobbler machine for nearly two months, said he had become accustomed to the equipment and described it as effective for cleaning markets. The machine, equipped with a vacuum system, rotating brush and water tanks, is currently deployed across the Inner and Outer Circle.

While workers acknowl-

edged that the machines have not reduced their workload significantly, they appreciated the technological upgrade. “The working hours remain the same because a lot of waste still has to be collected manually,” said sanitation worker Sandeep. Other workers highlighted regular maintenance schedules, multiple cleaning shifts and prompt administrative support.

Street vendors and local visitors also credited NDMC's continuous monitoring and disciplined cleaning schedule for improving hygiene standards in Connaught Place.

The comparison suggests that while mechanisation can enhance urban sanitation, its success depends on practical deployment, appropriate infrastructure and sustained operational support rather than symbolic implementation alone.

Traffic cops use e-rickshaw to save 45-year-old teacher

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two Delhi Traffic Police constables saved a 45-year-old government school teacher's life by rushing him to a hospital in an e-rickshaw instead of waiting for an ambulance after he allegedly attempted suicide by jumping from the Rani Jhansi Flyover here, officials said on Sunday.

The incident took place on July 8 at around 4 pm when traffic police person-

nel deployed at Azad Market Chowk received information that a man was attempting to jump from the flyover.

Constables Sahil and Amit rushed the injured man, later identified as government school teacher Anand Kumar Saroha (45), to Hindu Rao Hospital in a passing e-rickshaw before he was referred to St. Stephen's Hospital. Doctors said he is out of danger, with police crediting the constables' swift response for saving his life.

METRO, FLYOVERS AMONG CLEARED PROJECTS

Centre approves ₹1,647 crore for 28 Delhi infrastructure projects

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Centre has approved 28 major infrastructure projects worth Rs.1,647 crore for Delhi under the Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI) scheme, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Sunday. The Central government has also sanctioned an additional Rs.756 crore as an incentive for the Delhi government's efforts to increase capital expenditure (CAPEX) through its own resources.

According to the Chief Minister, the approved projects include Delhi Metro works, the Barapulla Elevated Corridor, the Karawal Nagar Flyover, EV charging stations at DTC depots and several key road infrastructure projects aimed at improving transport connectivity and public facilities across the national capital.

Calling the approval a major boost to the city's development, Gupta said, "In a landmark



decision aimed at strengthening the Capital's infrastructure, the Central Government has approved all 28 major capital projects proposed by the Delhi Government under the SASCI scheme. The total cost of these projects is Rs.1,647 crore."

She added that the additional incentive recognises the Delhi government's focus on increasing capital investment. "Recognising the Delhi Government's efforts to enhance

capital expenditure through its own resources, the Centre has also approved an additional incentive of Rs.756 crore," she said.

The Chief Minister said the approvals would accelerate infrastructure development and improve public amenities. "This decision will prove to be a significant milestone in further strengthening Delhi's infrastructure. It will accelerate development works across

CLOSER LOOK

» The Chief Minister said the approvals would accelerate infrastructure development and improve public amenities

» 'This decision will prove to be a significant milestone in further strengthening Delhi's infrastructure. It will accelerate development works across the Capital and enable citizens to benefit from improved public facilities'

the Capital and enable citizens to benefit from improved public facilities," she said.

Explaining the significance of the scheme, Gupta said SASCI provides interest-free financial assistance to states and Union Territories for capital infrastructure projects while also encouraging reforms and higher capital expenditure through financial incentives.

She said the Delhi government had consistently

pursued approval for its proposals under the scheme and all 28 projects received clearance on July 9.

According to her, the approval reflects the Centre's confidence in the Delhi government's commitment to reforms, financial discipline and efficient implementation of development projects.

The Finance Department has been tasked with coordinating with the concerned departments to ensure timely execution of the projects.

Highlighting the Centre's support, Gupta said, "The Central Government's support for Delhi's development is a strong reflection of the vision of 'Viksit Bharat'.

The approval granted to Delhi, along with the additional incentive, demonstrates that governments working with a clear development agenda, transparent governance and sound financial management receive the full support of the Central Government."

PM-UDAY rollout: CM seeks ₹100 cr

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at accelerating the grant of property ownership rights to lakhs of residents living in Delhi's unauthorised colonies, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has sought Rs.100 crore from the Centre for the first phase of implementing the revised Pradhan Mantri Unauthorised Colonies in Delhi Awas Adhikar Yojana (PM-UDAY). The proposed funding will support a technology-driven land survey system, district-level implementation cells and a citywide awareness campaign to streamline the property rights process.

In a letter to Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal, the Chief Minister requested that the financial assistance be sanctioned under the Urban Development Fund (UDF) to operationalise the revised PM-UDAY framework notified on April 6, 2026.

According to the Chief Minister's Office, the revised regulations provide a fresh legal framework for granting property rights to residents of unauthorised colonies. The scheme allows these colonies to be regularised on an "as-is-where-is" basis, a provision expected to simplify the process of issuing ownership documents to lakhs of eligible residents.

The Delhi government has designated the Revenue Department as the nodal agency for implementing the scheme. As part of the rollout, PM-UDAY cells will be established in all 13 districts of the city, with each unit headed by an Additional District Magistrate (ADM). These cells will oversee physical verification of properties, digital mapping, land record updates and processing of applications across Delhi's 1,511 unauthorised colonies.

The proposed Rs.100 crore allocation has been divided into three major components. Of the total, Rs.65 crore has been earmarked for developing a modern land survey and mapping system under the DRISHTI initiative. The technology-based system is expected to improve the accu-



'Revised regulations provide a fresh legal framework for granting property rights to residents of unauthorised colonies'

racy, transparency and efficiency of property verification and land record modernisation.

Another Rs.25 crore has been proposed for setting up PM-UDAY cells at the district level and the scheme headquarters. According to the proposal, these dedicated cells are essential to ensure that property documents and authorisation letters are issued within the prescribed 45-day timeline.

The remaining Rs.10 crore has been allocated for public awareness and outreach activities. The campaign will include workshops with Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), establishment of help desks, dissemination of Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs), awareness regarding eligibility criteria and timelines, and organisation of single-window camps to assist applicants.

In her letter, Gupta said, "The institutional framework required for implementing the scheme has already been notified and the work has commenced." She urged the Centre to approve the first-phase funding at the earliest, adding that "timely financial support from the Central Government will help ensure that lakhs of Delhi residents receive the benefits of property rights at the earliest and with greater ease."

The Chief Minister also expressed gratitude to the Centre for its continued support in implementing the PM-UDAY scheme and requested an early decision on the proposal along with the necessary approvals.

NDMC marks 32nd week of 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' drive

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Sunday organised the 32nd consecutive weekly plantation drive under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign at the Central Government Employees Residents' Welfare Association (RWA), Kali Bari Marg, Gole Market, with Vice-Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal leading the initiative.

The programme, held as part of the #EkPedMaaKeNaam_OnSunday campaign, also included a Jan Sunwai under the Good Governance at Your Doorstep initiative, where residents raised civic issues relating to local infrastructure and public amenities.

Addressing the gathering, Chahal said the campaign had evolved into a public movement with growing citizen participation. He noted that, besides the weekly drives, NDMC has been conducting large-scale plantation programmes in collaboration with universities, embassies and other institutions to strengthen urban green cover.

Residents planted saplings in honour of their mothers, in keeping with the campaign's objective of linking environmental conservation with public participation. Chahal urged citizens to ensure the regular care and protection of the saplings to help them grow into healthy trees. During the interaction, residents sought a new badminton court, an open gym, reconstruction of a porta cabin and solutions to sewer-related issues. Chahal reviewed the requests with officials from the Health, Civil Engineering, Roads, Water Supply, Drainage and Electricity Departments and directed them to ensure time-bound action



Driver held for staging ₹5 lakh robbery: Police

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested a 42-year-old driver for allegedly staging a fake gunpoint robbery to misappropriate Rs 5 lakh entrusted to him by his employer. Police said the case was cracked within four hours, with the entire cash recovered from a cloth bag hidden beneath the bonnet of the accused's car.

The driver, Gurnaam Singh alias Happy, had claimed that three armed men in a Thor SUV robbed him near Rohini. However, technical surveillance exposed inconsistencies in his account.

During questioning, he confessed to fabricating the robbery due to financial difficulties. Further investigation is underway. MPOST

Kejriwal visits Delhi petrol pump, service stn to hear consumers' E20 fuel concerns

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal on Saturday visited a petrol pump and service station in Delhi to interact with vehicle owners over their experience with E20-blended petrol, claiming that several consumers complained of reduced mileage and vehicle performance.

During the visit, Kejriwal spoke to people who had come for refuelling as well as those who had brought their vehicles for servicing.

He said the interaction helped him understand the concerns being raised by some vehicle owners regarding the use of ethanol-blended fuel.

In a post on X after the visit,



Kejriwal said, "Today, I went to a petrol pump and a service station in Delhi to understand the ground reality. Many people told me that their vehicles' mileage has reduced, and some also complained about mechanical issues."

The AAP leader said the government's claims on E20 fuel are "white lies," alleging that the ground reality differed.

He said public concerns on issues affecting daily life should

"The government should listen to people's grievances and work towards resolving them"

be heard and addressed.

"We live in a democracy. The government should listen to people's grievances and work towards resolving them," Kejriwal said.

The AAP leader also referred to the criticism faced by people who have raised concerns over E20-blended petrol, saying that those expressing their views on the issue should not be labelled or dismissed. "Those raising concerns

about E20 petrol are citizens who are sharing their experiences. Their concerns should be heard," he said.

Kejriwal said his visit was aimed at understanding the experiences of ordinary consumers and bringing their feedback into public discussion.

He added that decisions affecting people should take into account their feedback and concerns.

Last week, the government issued a detailed rebuttal to what it described as misinformation circulating on social media about the country's E20 ethanol blending programme, rejecting claims ranging from engine damage to insurance invalidation and environmental harm.

Two boys drown after falling into rainwater-filled pit in outer Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two children drowned after allegedly falling into a rainwater-filled pit while playing in an agricultural field in the outernorth Delhi's Mukhmelpur village on Sunday evening, police said.

The Delhi Fire Service (DFS) had received a call at 5.55 pm reporting that two children were feared to have drowned in the pit, following which two rescue teams were rushed to the spot.

Police later identified the victims as Ayush (8) and Nitin (10).

According to the police, a PCR call regarding the drowning of two minor children near Hiranki Road in Mukhmelpur village was received at 6.08 pm.

Preliminary investigation revealed that the boys

had gone to play in the fields behind a house around 4 pm when they accidentally fell into the pit excavated for drainage and storage of excess rainwater from adjoining fields.

"With the help of firefighters and locals, the children were pulled out of the pit and admitted to Satyawadi Raja Harish Chandra Hospital in Narela, where doctors declared them brought dead," the officer said.

The bodies were then sent to the mortuary at Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial Hospital in Jahangirpuri for post-mortem. A case was registered at Alipur Police Station.

Police said prima facie negligence is suspected on the part of the person responsible for maintaining or securing the water-filled pit.

They further said that an

investigation is underway to ascertain the circumstances leading to the tragedy and identify those responsible.

As news of the deaths spread through the village, anguished family members and residents gathered near the field, many breaking down in tears.

Residents said children from the locality often visited the area to play and occasionally entered the water-filled pit without realising its depth.

Locals said one boy jumped into the rainwater-filled pit to save his friend before both drowned.

Residents alleged there was no fencing or warning signs around the deep pit and demanded strict legal action against those responsible for leaving the hazardous site unsecured.

Zoo begins butterfly and dragonfly walks

NEW DELHI: The National Zoological Park (NZP) on Sunday launched a new citizen science initiative, with 21 participants documenting 12 butterfly species, seven dragonfly species and three damselfly species during its inaugural 'Sunday Butterfly and Dragonfly Walk'.

Held from 7 am to 10 am, the walk was led by naturalist and wildlife photographer Ramveer, along with volunteers, and drew butterfly enthusiasts, students, wildlife photographers and nature lovers. Participants recorded observations of more than 500 butterflies, dragonflies and damselflies across the Delhi zoo. The initiative aims to encourage citizens to contribute to documenting insect diversity while learning scientific methods of species identification, observation and biodiversity data recording.

Among the butterfly species recorded were Plain Tiger, Common Grass Yellow, Lime Butterfly and Yellow Orange Tip, while dragonflies such as Green Marsh Hawk, Scarlet Marsh Hawk and Wandering Glider, and damselflies including Golden Dartlet and Coromandel Marsh Dart, were also identified.

Ramveer highlighted the ecological importance of butterflies and dragonflies as pollinators, natural pest controllers and indicators of healthy ecosystems. The zoo also organised the fifth edition of its 'Sunday Bird Walk', led by bird expert Anand Prakash, during which participants recorded 45 bird species. MPOST

MANDATES DEMOLITION WITHIN 72 HOURS UNDER NEW SOP

L-G's zero-tolerance policy: DDA issues SOP, forms flying squads to check encroachments

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has operationalised the Lieutenant Governor's directive of adopting zero tolerance towards encroachments by issuing a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for the functioning of Flying Squad Teams (FSTs) and Quick Response Teams (QRTs). The move aims to strengthen enforcement to protect DDA and government land while preventing unauthorised construction and encroachments across the Capital.

The SOP has been framed to facilitate the early detection of unauthorised construction and encroachments, ensure



their prompt demolition and removal in accordance with legal provisions, and improve the protection of DDA-owned land. It also provides for the demolition of ongoing unauthorised construction on private land within Development Areas after due legal process. The framework clearly defines the responsibilities of the Land Management, Engineering and Horticulture Departments to

improve inter-departmental coordination.

As part of the enforcement mechanism, 14 Flying Squad Teams have been constituted across the DDA's zones to conduct regular field inspections. These teams will identify unauthorised constructions and encroachments, verify land ownership and status, document violations through geo-tagged photographs carrying

"SOP also introduces technology-driven monitoring through drone-based inspections, wherever required, and integrates field verification with the Vacant Land Monitoring System"

date and time stamps, and submit reports for immediate action. Wherever required, demolition will be carried out within 72 hours of detection.

The SOP also introduces technology-driven monitoring through drone-based inspections, wherever required, and integrates field verification with the Vacant Land Monitoring System (VLMS). This will enable regular updating

of land records, verification of vacant plots after demolition and continuous monitoring to prevent re-encroachment.

Four dedicated Quick Response Teams will carry out demolition and removal operations immediately after violations are identified and the requisite legal procedures are completed. They will submit demolition reports with geo-tagged before-and-after photographs, conduct videography wherever required and ensure DDA ownership boards are installed at the site. The revised framework also mandates continuous monitoring of cleared land to prevent fresh encroachments while reinforcing accountability through clearly defined timelines.

Capital's AQI touches 261, highest in 85 days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi's air quality deteriorated to the 'poor' category on Sunday, with the Air Quality Index (AQI) rising to 261, the highest in over 85 days. The reading was the highest since April 17, when the AQI stood at 263, after recording 140 on Saturday. Air quality had largely remained in the 'moderate' and 'satisfactory' categories for most of the month.

The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) attributed the deterioration to long-range transnational winds carrying mineral dust from storm activity in Afghanistan, Iran and Pakistan, which moved towards north-western India, including Delhi, leading to elevated PM10 concentrations. Strong winds across the Indo-Gan-

getic Plain further contributed to the spike, the commission said.

The CAQM said Delhi's air quality is likely to remain in the 'poor' category over the next few days before improving once the transnational dust spell subsides.

Despite the rise in pollution, the commission decided against invoking GRAP Stage-I restrictions, directing the Delhi Pollution Control Committee instead to intensify dust-control measures.

Meanwhile, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) recorded a maximum temperature of 36.8 degrees Celsius, 1.3 degrees above normal, and a minimum of 28.3 degrees Celsius. The heat index, or feels-like temperature, touched 45.7 degrees Celsius on Sunday evening.

IT CARRIES OUT THREE MAJOR TESTS

ISRO successfully carries out tests of Gaganyaan crew module systems

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) on Sunday said it had successfully carried out three major tests of the Gaganyaan crew module systems.

The first test pertained to ensuring an upright position for the crew module after splashdown in the sea, considered one of the most important crew safety requirements.

To do this, a stored cold-gas-based uprighting system was developed and tested.

"A system-level qualification test setup consisting of all the elements of CMUS (crew module uprighting system) was realised and successfully conducted inflation tests for the primary inflation module wherein stored gas in the high-pressure gas bottle was made to



inflate the floatation by operating the control valves," the ISRO said.

The second test involved examining the separation of the umbilical mechanism that

Highlights

- » The first test pertained to ensuring an upright position for the crew module after splashdown in the sea, considered one of the most important crew safety requirements
- » The second test involved examining the separation of the umbilical mechanism that serves as a link between the crew module, where astronauts live, and the service module, which provides power and propulsion
- » The mechanism consists of two parts, each located at the crew module side, called CSU-1, and the service module side, called CSU-2
- » The third test validated the structural integrity of the crew module during the apex cover separation event
- » The apex cover protects the parachutes and associated subsystems during the mission. It is separated before parachutes are deployed to decelerate the crew module

serves as a link between the crew module, where astronauts live, and the service module, which provides power and propulsion.

The mechanism consists of two parts, each located at the crew module side, called CSU-1, and the service module side, called CSU-2.

During the crew module's Earth re-entry stage, the service module first separates from the crew module after the CSU-1 disconnects. Subsequently, just before re-entry, the CSU-2 is also separated.

"Separation test of CSU-2 from simulated crew module was carried out. The test demonstrated the clean separation of CSU-2 as well as structural stability of the crew module panel and their interfaces," the space agency said.

The third test validated the structural integrity of the crew module during the apex cover separation event.

The apex cover protects the parachutes and associated subsystems during the mission. It is separated before parachutes are deployed to decelerate the crew module.

SC to hear plea seeking guidelines to curb 'unpredictable fluctuations' of airfares

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on July 13, a plea seeking regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfares and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta will hear the plea filed by social activist S Laxminarayanan, who also sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector.

On May 15, the top court said there should be some rationalisation of airfares and asked the Centre to provide relief to flyers, while flagging that on the same day, one airline flying in the same sector charges a particular airfare while other charges a different airfare.

The Centre, while not disputing the problem, has submitted that a new enactment Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam of 2024 has come into effect in January, 2025 and the corre-



sponding rules are in the process of consultation.

Laxminarayanan represented by senior advocate Ravindra Srivastava had contended that rules already existed under the Aircraft Act of 1937 but the problem was that they were not followed.

On November 17 last year, the top court sought responses from the Centre and others on the plea of Laxminarayanan.

Earlier, the Centre told the apex court that the Ministry of Civil Aviation was actively considering the issues raised in the plea.

While hearing the matter on January 19, the top court said it would interfere with the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfares and flagged the exorbi-

tant rise during festivals.

The top court had termed the exorbitant rise of airfares by the airlines as "exploitation" and asked the Centre and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to file their replies on the plea.

The plea claimed that all private airlines have, without any credible justification, reduced the free check-in baggage allowance for economy class passengers from 25 kg to 15 kg, "thereby converting what was earlier part of the ticketed service into a new revenue stream".

It said the "new policy of permitting only a single piece for check-in and the absence of any rebate, compensation or benefit to passengers who do not avail themselves of check-in baggage demonstrates the arbitrary and discriminatory nature of the measure".

The plea claimed that currently, no authority has the power to review or cap airfares or ancillary fees, allowing the airlines to exploit consumers through hidden charges and unpredictable pricing.

Kota: Doctors remove edge of axe from man's skull

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOTA: Doctors in a Kota hospital on Sunday carried out an over three-hour surgery to remove the edge of an axe that stuck deep into the skull of a man, after he was allegedly attacked by unidentified assailants while asleep, police said.

Ramjilal Shariya, 30, resident of Bhanwargarh police station area in Baran district, was attacked with an axe by an unidentified assailant on the intervening night of July 11-12 while he was asleep with his wife, Mamta and a daughter at his home, they said.

On the barking of the dogs, his wife woke up around 2 am and found her husband on the floor in a pool of blood with an axe stuck deep in the left side of his skull, the police said. With neighbours' help, he was rushed to the government hospital at Bhanwargarh,

where doctors referred him to the Bara district hospital, the doctors, after initial treatment, referred him to Kota.

The family, around 5 am on Sunday, reached NMCH hospital with Ramjilal bearing an axe with a handle into his skull. The patient was brought in critical condition with a 2.5 cm edge of an axe stuck deep into the left side of the skull, very low blood pressure and loss of blood, NMCH Neurosurgery HOD Dr SN Gautam said. The patient initially underwent treatment to stabilise his condition and BP and a medical examination to assess the damage. However, the CT scan turned challenging with the handling axe, he further said.

A team of doctors, around 3 pm, carried out a three-hour surgery and operated on the axe-edge, ensuring minimum damage to the brain cells, the HOD said.

Tunnel company directed to compensate Wayanad landslide victims' families: Minister

OUR CORRESPONDENT

WAYANAD: The company executing the tunnel project at Kalladi has been directed to provide immediate as well as long-term financial assistance to the families of those killed and injured in the July 7 landslide, Kerala Agriculture Minister T Siddique said on Sunday.

Eight people were killed in the July 7 landslide near the construction site of the road tunnel project at Kalladi, which is intended to connect Wayanad and Kozhikode districts.

Speaking at a review meeting held at the Collectorate, Siddique said the company had also been instructed to remove the earth that collapsed during the landslide and the soil dumped at the site as part of the tunnel work within three days.

The minister said an expert



People carry the mortal remains of a construction manager from Himachal Pradesh, recovered during a search operation following the landslide on Tuesday at the tunnel project site in Kalladi, Wayanad

committee would arrive in the district to inspect the accident site. He said the panel would examine the area and submit a report on how, when, from where, and in what manner the accumulated earth should be removed, and recommend safety measures.

The minister said the state government would provide Rs

two lakh as financial assistance to each of those injured in the landslide, while the company would provide Rs 2.5 lakh.

The company would also extend additional financial assistance to the three persons undergoing treatment in the critical care unit.

Siddique said the company had also been directed to pro-

vide immediate as well as long-term financial assistance to the families of those killed and injured in the landslide and disburse the amount to their accounts within 10 days.

He said school bus and Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) services would be ensured for students travelling from Chooralmala to schools in Meppadi.

He said the number of jeep services from Chooralmala would also be increased. Check posts would be set up on both sides of the Meenakshi river, while Fire and Rescue Services personnel, police and company representatives would be deployed to ensure the safe movement of people across the Meenakshi bridge. The Meppadi grama panchayat was directed to find alternative accommodation for the owners of a house below the Meenakshi bridge that was partially damaged in the landslide.

CRPF jawan found dead at Kota railway station; probe underway

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOTA: A 50-year-old CRPF jawan was found dead under suspicious circumstances at the Kota Railway Station, with police investigating the cause of death, officials said on Sunday.

The deceased, Amarendra Ray, a resident of Manikpur in Assam's Bongaigaon district, posted with the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) in Neemuch, Madhya Pradesh, was found lying unconscious on Platform No 2 of the railway station early Saturday, they said.

Circle Inspector, Government Railway Police (GRP), Kota, Guljari Lal said the station master informed police around 4.30 am that a man was lying unconscious on the platform.

A GRP team and a railway

doctor reached the spot, and the person was declared dead after examination, he said.

Documents recovered from his possession helped establish his identity. The body bore no visible injury marks, officer said.

After Ray's family members reached Kota on Sunday, the body was handed over to them after post-mortem and a case under section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) was lodged for investigation into the cause of death, Lal said, adding that the family has not levelled any allegations.

According to police, Ray had left his home on July 2 after spending holidays with family and was on his way to rejoin duty in Neemuch, though he stayed in a few cities en route.

From Page 1

Iranian retaliation

"We bombed the hell out of them last night," President Donald Trump told NBC's "Meet the Press."

Semiofficial Iranian news agencies reported that a navy officer was killed. Iran retaliated by attacking nations in the region hosting US military forces, while insisting it alone must control the strait and potentially charge vessels for travelling through it.

"The era of one-sided deals is OVER," Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, the speaker of Iran's parliament and a main negotiator, wrote. "We told you: keep your word or pay the price. Reality is knocking."

The US has launched three rounds of airstrikes targeting Iran in the last week over Iranian attacks on ships heading through the strait using a route off Oman, seeking to avoid the Islamic Republic's territorial waters.

The US military and Trump asserted that the strait remained open Sunday. Iran said the strait was closed until calm is restored, and it would consider targeting "additional enemy bases in the region" if it faced more attacks.

The US military said over 140 ships had transited the strait over the past week. A multinational body overseen by the US Navy said traffic continued "at reduced levels" off both Oman and Iran. It said nearly 140 vessels transited daily before the war.

About a fifth of all traded oil and natural gas passed through the strait before the war began. Iran's grip on it led to a global energy crisis, though oil prices have sharply dropped since wartime highs of USD 120 a barrel.

Missile alerts sounded across several Gulf Arab countries early Sunday.

Qatar's military said it intercepted incoming Iranian fire, with explosions heard in the neighbouring United Arab Emirates. Three people, including a child, were

wounded as a result of shrapnel from the interception of Iranian attacks, Qatar's Interior Ministry said, giving no further details on their condition.

Missile alerts sounded in Bahrain, an island kingdom in the Persian Gulf home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet. Kuwait's military also said it was intercepting incoming fire.

The Omani state news agency said drones struck sites in an area that sits on the Strait of Hormuz and issued a shelter-in-place warning for residents in the region. The attack came a day after Oman and Iran held talks on the strait.

Oman summoned the Iranian ambassador to protest the strikes, the first such move since the war began, calling Iran's acts "irresponsible."

Three Iranian missiles struck areas across Jordan, causing minor damage but no injuries, Jordan's state news agency reported.

Sirens also sounded in the UAE, but the government said missiles did not cross into its territory.

A Cyprus-flagged container ship was hit by Iran and suffered "significant engine room damage," the US Central Command said.

Oman's maritime authority said it rescued 23 crew members but one was missing. India's Ministry of External Affairs said the missing man is an Indian national and it was working with Oman to locate him.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations centre, overseen by the British military, said the ship had been hugging Oman's shoreline.

Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard said multiple vessels "disregarded our warnings" and ignored instructions to follow what it called an approved route. One "was struck by a warning shot and brought to a stop."

Iranian state media later reported US strikes across the country, including southern Iran in the province closest to the strait and military sites in a province near Tehran.

The strait sits in both Iran and Oman's territorial waters but has long been considered an international waterway.

Oman on Saturday said it and Iran agreed to continue discussing the strait "at the technical and political levels." Iran offered no statement about the strait being open to

all, something sought by the Trump administration.

Trump suggested last week that the interim deal in the war was "over." But mediators, including Pakistan, Qatar and Egypt, have continued efforts to reach an agreement.

A regional official involved in the mediation, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss those talks, said efforts to shore up the ceasefire continued Sunday.

Iran's new supreme leader, still unseen since his first statement since the funeral of his father, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, that Iranians would avenge his killing in the war's opening strikes on February 28.

Such revenge "is the will of our nation and must certainly be carried out," Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei said in a statement carried on state television.

India condemns

member was missing and the vessel suffered an onboard fire and major engine room damage, leaving it unable to continue its journey. The UK Maritime Trade Operations also reported a fire after the vessel was targeted early Sunday. Calling the repeated attacks on commercial shipping "deeply worrisome," India urged immediate de-escalation and a diplomatic solution. It said attacks on commercial shipping and civilian infrastructure must stop and safe navigation through international waterways should be restored in accordance with international law.

MPOST

EC makes parents

reduces the documents new voters need to submit along with the application," the official said.

The Election Commission has also integrated the declaration into the online application process. Applicants filling Form 6 digitally cannot proceed unless they complete the declaration.

Separately, the poll author-

ity defended the ongoing Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, dismissing concerns raised by United Nations Special Rapporteurs and maintaining that the exercise is transparent, constitutional and has the backing of the Supreme Court.

Election Commission officials said the revision is intended to ensure that all eligible Indian citizens are included in the electoral rolls while removing duplicate, deceased, shifted, absent and foreign voters.

The Commission also rejected allegations of large-scale deletion of minority voters, including claims related to Nandigram in West Bengal. Officials said voters were given adequate opportunities to challenge exclusions and denied that the exercise targeted any particular community.

The clarification comes after UN Special Rapporteurs, in a recent letter to the government, expressed concerns over the SIR process, alleging that it lacks transparency.

Monsoon

four to five days. It also said rainfall activity is likely to remain weak over northwest, west central and south Peninsular India during the next six to seven days.

Uttarakhand remained the worst-hit state, where the IMD issued a red alert for heavy to very heavy rainfall. Landslides triggered by persistent rain blocked 126 roads, including two national highways, according to the State Emergency Operation Centre. The Rishikesh-Yamunotri National Highway has remained closed for the past three days following a landslide at Syanachatti, where repair work continued on Sunday. In Dehradun, a woman was injured after a wall collapsed, while seven families were evacuated from the affected area.

Light to moderate rain continued in Himachal Pradesh. Jogindernagar in Mandi district recorded 60 mm rainfall during the past 24 hours, followed by Manali at 45 mm, Sarahan at 38.5 mm, Rohru at 25 mm and Shimla at 19 mm. In Shimla, debris and a

fallen tree blocked the Cart Road near the Lift opposite the Himachal Pradesh Congress Committee headquarters, disrupting traffic for several hours.

West Bengal also witnessed widespread rainfall. The IMD said an active monsoon would bring heavy rain to several districts until July 14. The sub-Himalayan districts are expected to continue receiving heavy showers, while Bankura, Birbhum, Purba Bardhaman, Paschim Bardhaman, Nadia and Murshidabad are also likely to receive heavy rainfall. Pundibari in Coochbehar district recorded the state's highest rainfall at 89 mm in the 24 hours ending Sunday morning.

Delhi and Rajasthan remained largely dry. Delhi recorded maximum temperatures of 35 to 36 degrees Celsius and minimum temperatures of 26 to 28 degrees Celsius, with no major change expected over the next week. Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar was the hottest place at 41.7 degrees Celsius. Uttar Pradesh also remained rain-free, with a 17 per cent seasonal rainfall deficit after receiving 158.8 mm against the normal 190.9 mm between June 1 and July 12. Rain and thundershowers are expected in parts of eastern Uttar Pradesh, while Rajasthan may see light rain in some eastern districts between July 13 and 15 along with dust-laden winds of 30 to 40 kmph in western areas.

Panel proposes

allowing for reappointment.

The committee further recommended that cases involving high-level constitutional functionaries be heard in fast-track or special courts in line with Supreme Court directions.

If the recommendations are accepted, the Ministry of Home Affairs will place the proposed amendments before the Union Cabinet before introducing official amendments in the Lok Sabha.

Former Qatari Emir Sheikh

PARLIAMENT SESSION IS SCHEDULED FROM JULY 20 TO AUGUST 13

Monsoon Session: Oppn to raise Ram temple, NEET paper leak issues

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The INDIA Bloc will seek to corner the Centre in the upcoming Parliament session over issues like the Ram temple donation case and the NEET paper leak, while also resisting the BJP's alleged attempts to secure a two-thirds majority by engineering defections in Opposition parties, RJD MP Sudhakar Singh said.

The Monsoon Session of Parliament is scheduled from July 20 to August 13.

In an interview to news agency on Sunday, the Buxar MP alleged that the BJP was pursuing a political strategy to weaken Opposition parties in an attempt to secure the numbers required to push through its legislative agenda.

"The BJP wants to achieve a two-thirds majority by breaking Opposition parties across the country. The INDIA Bloc will oppose that unitedly. We

Highlights

» The BJP wants to achieve a two-thirds majority by breaking Opposition parties across the country'

» Sudhakar Singh alleged that the BJP's efforts to

weaken the Opposition were part of a broader attempt to undermine the Constitution

» Singh expressed support for the ongoing protest at Jantar Mantar led by Sonam Wangchuk and CJP

will raise every burning issue -- from the Ram Mandir donation theft and the paper leak to unemployment, corruption and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls," Singh said.

Asked about the recent defections by Opposition MPs and speculation of more to come, Singh said the concern extended across the INDIA Bloc.

"Earlier, defections happened within the framework of the law. Today, it appears even those safeguards are being

ignored. Every Opposition party is concerned because the ruling party is trying to weaken its rivals despite lacking the numbers on its own," he alleged.

Singh alleged that the BJP's efforts to weaken the Opposition were part of a broader attempt to undermine the Constitution.

"The 2024 Lok Sabha election was fought on the issue of saving the Constitution. People used to ask how the Constitution could be weakened. Today, we are seeing it happen through the laws being framed and the

actions being taken," he alleged.

Referring to the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Singh alleged that the exercise was an attack on citizens' voting rights.

"The right to vote is a democratic right. If genuine voters are deleted from the electoral rolls, governments can be changed through the voter list rather than through the ballot. Once you capture the voter list, you capture the election," he alleged.

He claimed that if such practices continued, elections in India would resemble those in "China, Russia and North Korea, where almost all votes go to the ruling party, leaving only the illusion of democracy".

Singh said the Opposition would also strongly resist legislations such as 'One Nation, One Election', delimitation and other measures that, according to him, weaken the Constitu-

tion and democratic rights.

"If the government brings legislations such as One Nation, One Election, delimitation or any other law that weakens the Constitution or curtails democratic rights, the INDIA Bloc will oppose them both inside Parliament and on the streets," he said.

Calling the alleged NEET paper leak a "national crisis", Singh expressed support for the ongoing protest at Jantar Mantar led by climate activist Sonam Wangchuk and the Cockroach Janta Party.

"I stand 100 per cent with the students and their movement. This is no longer just about an examination. It is a crisis of trust in India's education system. Students have suffered irreparable losses, families have exhausted their savings, and many young people have slipped into depression. It has become a national crisis," he said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

J&K CM Omar takes statehood movement to national capital

Major protest at Jantar Mantar on July 20

OUR CORRESPONDENT



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah during the 'Delhi Chalo- We Want Our Statehood' rally, in Jammu

PTI

JAMMU: Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Sunday asserted that the July 20 demonstration in Delhi will mark the beginning of a new phase in the party's campaign for statehood to the Union Territory.

Abdullah was addressing a well-attended public rally at Maharaja Hari Singh Park — his first major public meeting in Jammu city in many years. The rally assumed significance as it was held in the BJP stronghold.

The gathering came a day after the National Conference organised a grand workers' convention at the mausoleum of Abdullah's grandparents in the Hazratbal area here, held to mark the 26th death anniversary of his grandmother, Akbar Jehan.

Abdullah paid his tributes to her on the stage amid cheering by thousands of party workers and a sea of flags and

banners demanding statehood.

A large banner on the stage proclaimed, "Delhi Chalo! We Want Our Statehood," whereas placards bore the slogans: "Hamari Riyasat, Hamari Shaan" and "Hamari Riyasat, Hamara Haq."

"Enough is enough! There will be no more waiting!" the chief minister said at the rally.

He said the party's silence was being mistaken for weakness.

"Our decency is being taken for granted. Our silence is being mistaken for weakness,

and our patience is being tested beyond its limits.

"After enduring every taunt hurled at us by the BJP, facing constant accusations, and confronting every conspiracy against our party, we have reached the conclusion that the time has come to take to the streets," Abdullah said.

Meanwhile, Peoples Democratic Party chief Mehbooba Mufti has been placed under house arrest ahead of Mar-tyrs' Day observance here, her daughter Iltija Mufti claimed on Sunday.

PM Modi returned with diplomatic gains, Rahul 'conspiring' abroad: BJP

NEW DELHI: The BJP on Sunday presented a 'report card' on the outcomes of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent foreign tours and attacked Rahul Gandhi, saying the prime minister returned having secured a victory for the country, while the Congress leader, who is abroad, must be "conspiring" behind closed doors.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters here, party spokesperson Sam-bit Patra cited Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto's remarks that he adopted many of Modi's policies, and took a dig at Gandhi, saying if the Congress leader had emulated Modi "even a little bit", he would not have lost 99 elections.

Patra also took on the Con-

gress and other Opposition parties, citing New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon's remarks acknowledging the transformation in India under Modi's leadership.

"Just think what New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon said. And the Congress party in India refuses to accept it. I think our Opposition should also learn something," he said.

Patra highlighted various achievements of Modi's three-nation tour of Indonesia, Aus-

tralia and New Zealand and said, "The prime minister went on a (foreign) tour and Rahul Gandhi too. The PM returned having brought victory to the nation, while Rahul Gandhi is surely conspiring behind closed doors."

Gandhi is likely "plotting" how to disrupt the good work being done under PM Modi's leadership, Patra charged further.

"You must be wondering where 'Rahul Baba' is. Go ahead, try to find out. A programme scheduled for him in Prayagraj on July 10 was postponed. There was an event in Patna as well; that too was postponed. There seem to be stamps on his passport from places like London, Iceland, and Germany, who knows? He is off on a tour," the BJP MP added.

MPOST

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Sunday launched a nationwide signature campaign demanding strict punishment for those allegedly involved in the donation theft at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, following which a Sundarkand recitation programme was organised by the party at the Japanese Park in Rohini.

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal said the campaign was being launched with the blessings of Lord Hanuman and appealed to people to participate by signing letters addressed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking strict action against those responsi-



AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal during the launch of a nationwide signature campaign, in New Delhi

PTI

ble for what the party termed "chanda-chori" at the temple.

As part of the campaign, Kejriwal appealed to people

to organise Hanuman Chalisa recitations and Hanuman Aarti at their homes, residential societies and other localities, gather devotees and encourage them to sign the letter addressed to the prime minister.

He noted that the signature campaign would be carried out across the country and was not limited to AAP workers.

He also said Ram devotees and people who were hurt by the alleged developments would participate in the campaign, with signed letters later being sent to the prime minister.

Addressing a press conference, Kejriwal accused those responsible for the alleged misconduct related to the Ram

temple of being shielded from accountability and called for strict punishment for them.

Meanwhile, the Delhi BJP criticised the AAP's move, with Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra alleging that organising Sundarkand recitations was a "political gimmick" aimed at reviving Kejriwal's political fortunes.

He accused Kejriwal of using religious programs for political advantage and questioned why the Sundarkand recitation initiatives announced by the AAP government in 2024 had not been continued.

He also alleged that the initiative was aimed at influencing voters in states where elections are due.

Haryana govt's sensitivity towards justice strengthening judicial infra in state: CJI



CJI Justice Surya Kant being welcomed by Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini at Gurugram

MPOST

MPOST BUREAU

GURUGRAM: Chief Justice of India, Justice Surya Kant said that the construction of judicial complexes equipped with state-of-the-art facilities is a clear reflection of the Haryana government's sensitivity and commitment towards strengthening the justice delivery system.

Owing to the proactive support of the state government, judicial infrastructure in Haryana is being significantly strengthened, and judicial buildings such as the Tower of Justice will contribute to creating a more conducive environment for the administration of justice.

The Chief Justice of India was addressing the gathering at the inauguration ceremony of the Tower of Justice in Gurugram on Sunday.

CJI inaugurated the 'Tower of Justice' judicial complex in Gurugram on Sunday in the presence of Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini.

CJI Surya Kant, CM Saini and other dignitaries honoured the workers who contributed to the construction of the Tower of Justice by presenting them with mementoes.

Justice Surya Kant recalled that in January 2017, while serving as a Judge of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, he had the privilege of performing the ceremony of this judicial complex.

Amit Shah launches massive tree plantation campaign in Gandhinagar

Lays foundation of various development projects

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GANDHINAGAR: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday launched a massive tree plantation campaign and inaugurated and laid the foundation of many development projects in Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency of Gujarat.

Shah said that more than one crore saplings have been planted in Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency on this occasion and about 50 lakh trees have been planted in Ahmedabad city.

He said that this campaign to plant 1.25 crores of trees has become a people's move-



ment under the able leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, which promotes the idea of "People, Planet with Progress".

Shah said that the Central Armed Police Forces have planted more than seven crore trees in the country in the last seven years and added that only

native species of trees with the lifespan of more than 100 years are planted to revive the natural ecosystem.

The Home minister inaugurated 61 new Oxygen Parks in Gandhinagar constituency and said that these Oxygen Parks in addition to 73 already inaugurated have made Ahmedabad one of the greenest cities in the country. He said that a scientific process has been initiated to provide saplings to those who have volunteered to plant trees.

Shah said that this campaign will lower down the temperature of Ahmedabad by at least five percent in the days to come.

FRESH DETAILS REVEAL ACCUSED OPERATED IN COORDINATED MANNER

Ram Temple donation 'theft': CCTV shows gang carried out 70 thefts in 40 days

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: Fresh details in the Ram Temple donation theft case have revealed that the accused operated in a coordinated manner, with one member assigned the task of physically stealing cash while others shielded him from suspicion. Investigators have found that the gang carried out around 70 thefts over a span of 40 days, averaging nearly two thefts every day.

According to the Special Investigation Team (SIT) and the police investigation, accused Avinash Shukla was primarily responsible for lifting cash from the donation collection.

CCTV footage, now part of the police evidence, shows him stealing money on nearly 50 occasions, making him the most active member of the gang.

Other accused, including Manish and Ramashankar, also allegedly stole cash

Ram temple trust to decide CEO's powers, no 'government interference', says Nripendra Mishra

AYODHYA: Ram Temple Construction Committee Chairman Nripendra Mishra on Sunday stated that the responsibilities and powers of the first-ever Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Ayodhya temple will be determined by the temple Trust.

The primary responsibility of the CEO will be to uphold the faith of the devotees in the trust, he said.

"The new CEO will also oversee financial arrangements," Mishra told reporters in Ayodhya, adding that there won't be any 'government interference' in the functioning of the trust or its CEO.

on several occasions before the proceeds were divided among the group.

Police said the CCTV footage corroborates the findings of the SIT, which had earlier concluded that the thefts were systematic and continued uninterrupted for over a month. During custo-

dial interrogation, Avinash reportedly admitted that he was usually entrusted with stealing the cash while the others ensured that no one noticed his actions.

Investigators have also uncovered the roles played by the other accused. According to the probe, Anukalp Mishra

Mishra added that ensuring that devotees visiting Ayodhya receive all necessary amenities and maintaining their trust in the temple will be among the new CEO's initial responsibilities.

"In a way, the CEO will work as an assistant of the trust, sans government interference," Mishra said, noting that a three-member panel has been set up to recommend suitable candidates for the CEO's post to the trust.

Ultimately, it is up to the trust to determine how much authority to delegate to the CEO, who will be responsible for arranging their own staff, while everything remains under the trust's purview, Mishra stated.

MPOST

carried out.

Once the timing was decided, Avinash would remove the cash from the donation collection, while Manish and Ramashankar occasionally carried out similar thefts. The stolen money was later shared among the members of the group, investigators said.

The CCTV footage further indicates that the accused usually stole money twice a day and, on some occasions, even three times. During police remand, Avinash, Anukalp and Lavkush allegedly admitted that they generally struck twice daily, although there were days when circumstances made it difficult to carry out the thefts.

The SIT's detailed inquiry is in its final stages, while the police investigation is expected to continue as officers gather additional evidence and record statements before filing the final chargesheet.

Nation Briefs

EX-BJD MLA PRAVAT BISWAL JOINS BJP IN PRESENCE OF CM MAJHI

BHUBANESWAR: Former BJD MLA Pravat Ranjan Biswal on Sunday joined the ruling BJP along with a large number of supporters here in the presence of Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi and state BJP president Manmohan Samal. Biswal, who was expelled from the BJD for opposing the selection of a party candidate for the Rajya Sabha elections in March this year, reached the BJP state headquarters from Master Canteen Square in a procession. "I joined the BJP after being influenced by the ideals and pro-people works of Prime Minister Narendra Modi," Biswal said. Welcoming Biswal to the saffron party, Majhi said, "It is a big blow to the BJD. Biswal's joining will strengthen the BJP, and it will have an impact in the entire Cuttack district. Pravat Babu is a popular leader, and his joining the BJP will open a new chapter in Cuttack politics."

PAK INTRUDER RETREATS AFTER BSF FIRES WARNING SHOTS IN J&K'S KATHUA

JAMMU: A Pakistani intruder retreated across the International Border after Border Security Force personnel fired warning shots when he attempted to enter Indian territory in Jammu and Kashmir's Kathua district on Sunday, officials said. BSF troops observed the intruder's movement in the Bobiya area of Hiranagar sector this evening and challenged him, the officials said. However, the intruder paid no heed and tried to approach the border fence but retreated after alert BSF personnel fired a couple of shots to warn him, they said.

K'TAKA TOP DESTINATION

Nepal sends maximum foreign students to India: Edu Min Survey

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) for 2023-24 noted that India's higher education institutions attracted students from 173 countries
- » In 2023-24, the highest share of foreign students came from Nepal (24.1%), followed by the UAE (7%), the US (5.9%), Bangladesh (5.9%), Nigeria (5.5%) and Zimbabwe (4%)
- » Karnataka emerged as the top destination for international students, with 7,914 foreigners enrolled in its HEIs, narrowly ahead of Punjab (7,902)



REPRESENTATIVE PIC
» Maharashtra (6,190), Uttar Pradesh (5,953) and Tamil Nadu (5,694) completed the top five list of hosting foreign students

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Nepal continues to send the largest number of students to India while Karnataka is the top destination receiving maximum foreign students, according to a Ministry of Education survey.

The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) for 2023-24 noted that India's higher education institutions attracted students from 173 countries in the 2023-24 academic year, with 58,134 foreign students enrolled across universities and colleges in the country.

The AISHE collects detailed information from higher education institutions (HEIs) across the country through a web-based data capture format (DCF). Institutions upload data on student enrolment, faculty and staff, infrastructure, examination results, etc., on the AISHE portal.

The survey serves as the primary source of official statistics on higher education in India, providing critical insights for

policy formulation, planning and monitoring of the sector.

In 2023-24, the highest share of foreign students came from Nepal (24.1 per cent), followed by the UAE (7 per cent), the US (5.9 per cent), Bangladesh (5.9 per cent), Nigeria (5.5 per cent) and Zimbabwe (4 per cent).

The top 10 countries constituted 63.8 per cent of the total foreign students in 2023-24.

According to the report, Karnataka emerged as the top destination for international students, with 7,914 foreigners enrolled in its HEIs, narrowly ahead of Punjab (7,902).

Maharashtra (6,190), Uttar Pradesh (5,953) and Tamil Nadu (5,694) completed the top five list of hosting foreign students.

The highest number of foreign students were enrolled in undergraduate courses at 73.6 per cent, followed by postgraduate programmes at 16.8 per cent.

A total of 42,779 students were pursuing undergraduate programmes, accounting for

nearly 74 per cent of the total. Of these, 27,849 were men and 14,930 women.

Another 9,845 students were enrolled in postgraduate programmes, while comparatively smaller numbers pursued diploma, PhD, certificate and integrated courses.

Foreign student enrolments rose from 48,898 in 2019-20 to 58,134 in 2023-24, an increase of 9,236 students, or 18.9 per cent, over five years.

The growth was driven by both men and women students. While male enrolments increased from 32,386 to 37,295, the number of women students rose from 16,512 to 20,839 during the same period.

India also received foreign students from Lebanon, Burkina Faso, Mongolia, Mexico, Kazakhstan, Belarus and Chile, among others, in the 2023-24 academic year.

The Ministry of Education had launched the Study in India (SI) programme in 2018 with an aim to attract international students to pursue higher education in India.

CONSERVATIONISTS FLAG CONCERNS OVER COMMITTEE'S FUNCTIONING

‘Top wildlife panel cleared 96.5% of projects on protected land in a decade’

NEW DELHI: The Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL), the country's apex wildlife conservation watchdog, approved 96.5 per cent of the industrial and infrastructure proposals placed before it over the past decade, according to an analysis of official records that has renewed concerns among conservationists over its functioning.

Reportedly, an examination of minutes of meetings available online since 2016 shows that the committee held "52 meetings during this period and dealt with 2,448 development proposals concerning protected forest land. Of these, 572 proposals were deferred. Among the 1,876 projects that were considered, 1,810 received clearance while only 66 were rejected". The committee's functioning has come under fresh scrutiny after a petition filed before the Delhi High Court last week by 10 conservationists and activists alleged that the SC-NBWL was "recklessly clearing projects" at a very high approval rate.

Hearing the matter on Wednesday, the Delhi High Court questioned the Centre over "treating every statutory body as an extension of the government's arm". A bench comprising Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

Karia sought the government's response within four weeks.

The Standing Committee plays a crucial role because projects involving land within national parks, wildlife sanctuaries and tiger reserves are primarily cleared through it. Since the full National Board for Wildlife meets only occasionally, the committee's decisions effectively become final.

The NBWL, chaired by the Prime Minister, includes Members of Parliament, representatives of state governments, central ministries, research institutions, five representatives from non-governmental organisations and 10 eminent conservationists and ecologists nominated by the Centre. The Standing Committee is headed by the Union Environment Minister and includes senior forest and environment

officials and experts. The data also shows consistently high approval rates over the years. In 2018, 2021 and the first meeting of 2026, every proposal considered by the committee was approved. Even in 2020, when the approval rate was at its lowest, the committee cleared 82 of the 92 proposals considered, translating into an approval rate of nearly 89 per cent. In March this year, the committee considered 70 proposals, deferred nine and cleared all the remaining 61 projects. Its latest, 91st meeting, was held in Coimbatore on July 9, where more than 100 proposals were taken up.

According to the agenda, 118 proposals were listed for appraisal, including 24 defence projects, 23 road and bridge projects and 12 power transmission line proposals. AGENCIES

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Tea vendor kills man over Rs 10 dispute

NAGPUR: A 45-year-old labourer was allegedly stabbed to death by a tea vendor over a dispute involving Rs 10 in Nagpur's Kapilnagar area on Sunday, police said.

The incident took place around 3.30 pm after workers had begun dismantling a stage used for Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis's event. The victim, identified as Manoj Vishwanath Yadav, had gone to a tea stall after attending the programme.

Police said an argument broke out when tea vendor Kailash Lalchand Ganvir (42) demanded Rs 10 for tea and tobacco. During the altercation, Yadav allegedly slapped Ganvir, who then allegedly stabbed him in the neck with a knife. Yadav was declared dead at Mayo Hospital.

The accused has been arrested and further investigation is underway. MPOST

Amarnath Yatra: CISF DG reviews security

SRINAGAR: Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) Director General Praveer Ranjan on Saturday reviewed security arrangements for the ongoing Amarnath Yatra and held a series of meetings with security agencies and civil authorities at the Nunwan base camp in Pahalgam.

The CISF chief, accompanied by Additional Director General (North) Sudhir Kumar and DIG (North Zone-2), inspected the pilgrim base camps and assessed the overall security preparedness, including deployment of forces, surveillance systems, communication networks, check-posts and medical arrangements.

During the visit, Ranjan reviewed security installations, the communication centre, Quick Reaction Teams



(QRTs), Quick Action Teams (QATs), the CCTV control room, the Joint Police Control Room (JPCR) and logistics arrangements. He was also briefed on anti-sabotage measures, area domination exercises, crowd management, road security and emergency response mechanisms.

The DG visited jawan barracks, pilgrim camps and medical centres and interacted with security personnel, medical staff and women personnel deployed for the yatra. MPOST

CM Saini reviews preparations for PM Modi's July 17 Jind visit

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday visited Jind to review preparations for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's proposed visit to the district on July 17 and directed officials to ensure that all arrangements are completed on time.

The Chief Minister inspected Eklayva Stadium, the venue for the programme, and reviewed the layout, including the main pandal, sector-wise seating arrangements, parking facilities, media lounge, security measures and other logistical preparations. He instructed officials to leave no gaps in the arrangements for the high-profile event.

Saini said the Prime Minister would flag off the country's first hydrogen-powered train from Jind during the visit. The



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini chairs a meeting regarding preparations for PM Narendra Modi's upcoming visit to Jind

train, which will run between Jind and Sonapat, will mark a significant achievement for both Haryana and the country.

He added that the Prime Minister would also inaugurate and lay the foundation stones for development projects worth several crores across different districts of Haryana, benefiting people across the state.

Describing the Prime Minister's visit as a matter of pride for Haryana, Saini said administrative officials, public representatives and party workers should work in close coordination to ensure the programme's success. After inspecting the venue, the CM chaired a review meeting at the PWD Rest House with ministers, senior officials and public representatives. The discussions focused on traffic management, the availability of CNG buses and electric vehicles, parking facilities and visitor movement. MPOST

UP: Woman drinks acid mistaking it for water

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

HAPUR: A woman is battling for her life after she allegedly drank acid from a bottle she believed contained drinking water while shopping at a jewellery store in Hapur district on Friday evening.

The incident took place in the Arjun Nagar area, where the woman had gone to purchase jewellery. Feeling thirsty, she asked for drinking water. An employee of the jewellery shop went to a nearby confectionery store and returned with what appeared to be a sealed bottle of water. The woman opened the bottle and took a sip. Within seconds, she screamed in pain, rushed out of the shop and spat out the liquid. CCTV footage from the jewellery store captured the woman taking a sip before running outside in distress. The bottle allegedly contained acid instead of water. As her condition worsened, she was first taken to a local hospital and later referred to a medical college, where she remains in critical condition and is undergoing treatment.

Police have detained the owner of the confectionery shop for questioning. During the investigation, officers recovered several bottles containing acid from the shop. They are trying to ascertain how the acid came to be inside a bottle that appeared to be factory sealed and whether there was any negligence or deliberate act involved. The confectionery shop owner has maintained that the bottle was sealed when it was taken out of the refrigerator and handed over to the jewellery shop employee.

Jewellery shop owner Denu also said the bottle appeared to be intact when it was purchased. "To the best of our knowledge, the bottle was completely sealed. We handed it to the customer exactly as it was when we took it out of the fridge," he said.

Police are examining the recovered bottles and CCTV footage to determine the circumstances that led to the incident.

Khattar calls for ‘sustainable and tech-driven’ public works

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Public Works Department (CPWD) on Sunday celebrated its 172nd Annual Day in New Delhi, with Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal Khattar urging the organisation to adopt sustainable construction practices, modern technology and institutional reforms to improve public works projects.

Addressing the function, the minister stressed the need for eco-friendly construction methods, the use of advanced technologies and timely completion of projects. He also called for the development of an online system for transfer and posting of personnel and asked the department to contribute towards the Prime Minister's vision of Viksit Bharat.

Referring to the guiding principles of Speed, Accessibility, Integrity, Duty, Technology Adoption, Public Welfare and Transparency, collectively termed SAI DUTY, the minister said CPWD should work with a citizen-centric approach and leverage technology to ensure digital governance and transparency.

During the event, he released several publications, including technical manuals, the annual in-house magazine Nirman Bharati, e-NIRMIT ERP modules and books titled India's Urban Transformation: Reflections from Policy and Practice and India's Urban Momentum: Towards Making Our Cities Liveable.

The minister also presented Director General's medals, commendation certificates and certificates of merit to individuals and organisations for excellence in completed projects. Certificates were also distributed to participants of capacity-building programmes conducted in association with premier institutions.

Housing and Urban Affairs Secretary Srinivas Katikithala proposed the creation of a National Council for Public Works to promote innovation, standardisation and collaboration among governments, academia and industry.

CPWD Director General Satinder Pal Singh highlighted the department's achievements and reaffirmed its commitment to upskilling manpower, adopting technologies and promoting sustainable construction practices.

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AGITATION GETS LEADERS' SUPPORT

CJP protest: Wangchuk's health ‘worsens’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Educator and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk's health declined further on Sunday, on the 15th day of his hunger strike, with doctors reporting a drop in his blood pressure and a total weight loss of 7.8 kg since the fast began.

The Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar in Delhi over alleged examination irregularities entered its 23rd day on Sunday, with Samajwadi Party MP Pushpendra Saroj and former Kerala health minister K K Shailaja in attendance.

Shailaja, and former Kerala ministers K N Balagopal and P Rajeev, also extended support to the agitation.

According to a health update shared by the outfit,



Sonam Wangchuk being attended by a medical professional as CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke looks on during a hunger strike

Wangchuk's blood pressure was recorded at 104/66 mm Hg, and total weight loss at 7.8 kg. CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke shared the health update on X. "Day 15 of Sonam Wangchuk's hunger strike. When will the government wake up???"

he wrote.

Addressing the gathering, Shailaja said: "We are all here to express our solidarity with the protest conducted by the CJP. It is on an important issue. We want accountability in examinations. We want a

fair entrance examination system in our country." She alleged that repeated paper leaks could not have taken place without the ministry's knowledge and backed the protesters' demand for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation.

"It is a great scam. They are selling the future of our students by leaking question papers. Twenty young students have committed suicide over this issue. The central government should compensate their families and ensure a fair and accountable examination system in future," she said.

In a post on X, the CJP said Saroj, one of the youngest members of the Lok Sabha, visited Jantar Mantar to "amplify the voices of students protesting against the continuous paper leaks and irregularities."

USING HUMOUR TO REDUCE STIGMA

Cancer survivors find ‘Comedy in Chaos’ in bid to normalise disease

NEW DELHI: From bearing with people's unsolicited advice to dealing with the incessant hairfall, a bunch of women in their "tryst with cancer" refused to let the disease define them and chose to find comedy in the everyday struggles of surviving the Big C.

While Rohini Khuller took pride in being "bald and beautiful" when her doctor failed to recognise her without the hair, Nandita Thakur accepted being christened "Baldlocks" at her tequila party to mark the "chemo kickoff".

Meanwhile, Ujala Makhija channelled her creativity and turned into an artist, drawing a new pair of eyebrows each morning.

The lecture room at India International Centre Annex on Saturday buzzed with the excitement and abrupt laughter of a college reunion as long-smiles faces broke into broad smiles and cancer-related puns flowed freely.

Khuller, along with a group of 10 "tryst with cancer" people -- who would rather not be

- ### KEY POINTS
- » From bearing with people's unsolicited advice to dealing with the incessant hairfall, a bunch of women in their 'tryst with cancer' refused to let the disease define them
 - » They chose to find comedy in the everyday struggles of surviving the Big C



» The nearly two hours of an unconventional gathering of former cancer patients and oncologists saw talk shows, skit, stand-up comedy, and a live music band

recognised as survivors, fighters, or warriors – put together "Comedy in Chaos", a show intended to use humour to normalise conversations about cancer and reduce stigma associated with it.

The nearly two hours of an unconventional gathering of former cancer patients and oncologists saw talk shows, skit, stand-up comedy, and a live music band, all of which were eagerly received by the audiences who were all too

familiar with the medical lingo, the absurdity of the ailment, and the collective experience of survival humour.

The idea for the evening, Khuller said, was borne out of a conversation she had with her oncologist some three years ago. "She said, 'I wish we had more cancer warriors like you', I immediately stopped her and said, 'Don't call me that. I am not a warrior, did I have a weapon? All you doctors had all the weapons possible, all I did was lie back'. And I won't complete the statement," Khuller said with a dramatic pause, letting a rapturous audience take in the hint.

"Then we started talking about how important it was to try and normalise cancer and somehow that word got me somewhere and I said, 'I really want to do something to remove this fear, let's encourage conversations that are normal,'" she added.

The evening opened with Thakur, Makhija and Jenus Pannu Kohli sharing their experiences when they first got to know about their diagnosis.

For Kohli, it was akin to entering the marriage market where finding a perfect doctor is more difficult than finding a perfect partner.

"There is no matrimonial website for doctors," she feigned disappointment.

While Makhija found a "loyal companion" in constipation, Thakur remembered dreading the mornings when it would be difficult to get out of the bed. AGENCIES

UT GETS 17 NEW TEHSILS

LG Saxena approves comprehensive reorganisation of tehsils in Ladakh

MPOST BUREAU

LEH: In a landmark administrative reform, Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena approved a comprehensive reorganisation and rationalisation of tehsils and revenue villages, following the creation of five new districts in the Union Territory, an official spokesman said on Sunday.

Under this reorganisation, 17 new tehsils have been created in Ladakh, taking the total number of tehsils to 32, from the existing 15, the spokesman said. He added that the move aims to operationalise the new districts while bringing public services to the people's doorsteps, thereby strengthening governance at the grassroots.

He said the new tehsils have been created on the recommendations of a UT-Level Committee constituted by Saxena, following the notification of the new districts on April 27 this year.

The committee observed serious lacunae in the existing administrative units, including tehsils and revenue villages, as they were not clearly

delineated.

It found that boundaries of several tehsils extended across more than one district, resulting in administrative overlap and operational challenges.

To address these issues, the spokesman said every revenue village has been mapped to a single tehsil and every tehsil to a single district, thereby creating a transparent, logical and efficient administrative structure while ensuring that no changes are made to the territorial boundaries of any district.

The decision, therefore, establishes a clear and streamlined revenue administrative framework for the newly created districts and would significantly improve administrative efficiency, public service delivery and local governance, he said.

Saxena also directed the chief secretary to immediately appoint tehsildars, with one officer assigned to the independent charge of a tehsil to increase administrative efficiency.

Ladakh, one of India's largest Union Territories in geographical area, has long faced

administrative challenges due to its difficult terrain, sparse population, and remote habitations.

The creation of 17 new tehsils will significantly reduce travel distances for citizens (often exceeding 300 km) for availing government services, and ensure faster and more effective delivery of public services.

Following the reorganisation, Leh district will comprise five tehsils, Kargil seven, Changthang four, Nubra six, Zaskar four, Sham five and Drass one tehsil.

"The creation of new districts was done to bring governance closer to the people and make the administration more accessible, responsive and citizen-centric. With the operationalisation of these districts through a comprehensive reorganisation of Tehsils and Revenue Villages, we are establishing a robust administrative framework that will significantly improve revenue administration, strengthen grassroots governance and ensure faster implementation of developmental programmes.



EDITORIAL
JUSTICE AND
CREDIBILITY

Recent observations by the Delhi High Court, while hearing a matrimonial dispute involving allegations of rape and cruelty, have once again brought into focus a difficult but necessary conversation: how should the legal system respond when allegations of grave sexual offences emerge in the backdrop of matrimonial discord? The issue is not merely legal; it concerns public trust, the credibility of survivors, the rights of the accused and the integrity of institutions entrusted with dispensing justice.

The High Court's remarks deserve careful reading. The Court did not pronounce guilt or innocence, nor did it hold that allegations made in matrimonial disputes are inherently false. Instead, it drew attention to what it described as an emerging pattern where serious accusations of sexual offences are allegedly introduced in some cases to intensify pressure on the opposite party during family disputes. The Court linked this concern to the post-Arnesh Kumar legal landscape, where the Supreme Court curtailed the practice of automatic arrests under Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code, recognising the need to prevent misuse without diluting protection for genuine victims. According to the High Court's observations, there appears to be a concern that allegations carrying more severe penal consequences may sometimes be invoked to overcome the procedural safeguards that now exist in dowry-related prosecutions. Whether this trend is statistically significant is a matter requiring empirical study rather than anecdotal assumptions. Nevertheless, judicial observations of this nature cannot simply be dismissed because they arise from courts dealing daily with such disputes.

The challenge lies in resisting the temptation to reduce the debate to opposing slogans. To argue that every allegation in a matrimonial dispute is fabricated would be both legally unsustainable and morally indefensible. Domestic violence and marital abuse remain serious social realities in India. Women frequently encounter enormous social pressure, financial dependence, family honour and fear of retaliation before approaching the police. Delayed reporting of sexual offences, by itself, cannot become a ground for disbelieving a complainant because trauma, coercion and power imbalance often influence when and how victims disclose abuse. Indian courts have repeatedly recognised these realities. At the same time, it is equally true that the law cannot presume every accusation to be truthful merely because of its nature. Criminal jurisprudence rests on evidence, investigation and judicial scrutiny—not assumptions based on either gender or relationship. Both over-scepticism and unquestioning acceptance undermine justice.

What is therefore required is neither dilution of legal protections nor unquestioning endorsement of every complaint, but a more rigorous investigative framework. Police investigations in sensitive matrimonial disputes must become more professional, forensic and evidence-driven. Allegations should be tested against available documentary records, electronic communication, medical evidence where relevant, witness statements and surrounding circumstances rather than relying exclusively on competing narratives. Courts, too, must continue to distinguish between interim observations made while granting procedural relief and final findings after trial. Public discourse often blurs this distinction, treating judicial remarks during preliminary hearings as definitive conclusions. Such misinterpretations can unfairly prejudice both complainants and accused persons. Equally important is ensuring that investigators avoid approaching cases with preconceived notions—whether that women routinely misuse the law or that all allegations necessarily represent the truth. Justice requires neutrality, not stereotypes.

The broader lesson extends beyond any single case before the Delhi High Court. Laws dealing with domestic violence, dowry harassment and sexual offences were enacted because these crimes were historically under-reported and inadequately addressed. Weakening these protections because of concerns about occasional misuse would punish countless genuine victims who depend upon the legal system for safety and accountability. Conversely, ignoring instances where criminal law may be invoked strategically during matrimonial conflicts would erode public confidence in legal institutions and ultimately harm genuine complainants by fuelling scepticism towards all allegations. The credibility of the justice system depends not on choosing one concern over the other, but on safeguarding both. The law must remain a shield for victims, not a weapon in private disputes; equally, procedural safeguards must protect innocent persons without creating barriers for those seeking justice. Achieving that balance is difficult, but it remains the only path consistent with the constitutional promise of fairness, equality and the rule of law.

TALKING
SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER
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If E20 is indeed India's fuel future, it should succeed because India's citizens trust it, not because motorists discover too late that alternatives have disappeared. Sovereignty of choice is imperative for any policy's larger success

"Freedom is not worth having if it does not include the freedom to make mistakes."
— Mahatma Gandhi

A motorist pulls into a fuel station, expecting to choose between regular and premium petrol. Instead, he discovers that the choice has already been made for him. The question is no longer what octane he prefers, but whether he prefers ethanol at all. Across India today, that decision belongs less to the customer and more to policy. That is what is making India's E20 debate bigger than a dispute over fuel chemistry. It is a test of how a nation balances energy security with consumer confidence, national priorities with individual choice and technological transition with public trust.

India deserves credit for the ambition and speed of its ethanol programme. The target of achieving 20-per cent blending by 2030 was pre-achieved in 2025 itself, ahead of schedule. The Government says this has reduced dependence on imported crude, saved foreign exchange and created a market for agricultural feedstock like sugarcane and grain-based ethanol. In a country that imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude needs, these are not trivial achievements. But public policy succeeds not merely when targets are met. It succeeds when citizens feel confident that the transition is fair, transparent and suited to their realities.

Fuel Revolution

The scale of India's ethanol push is extraordinary, with blending rising from 1.5 per cent in 2015 to 20 per cent today. The programme has saved billions of dollars in imports while providing income streams to farmers and distilleries. Few economies have moved so quickly on biofuel blending. Supporters of the policy point to Brazil, where ethanol has long been part of the fuel ecosystem, and to the United States, where ethanol blends are widely used. The comparison is valid. Diversifying transport fuel sources is seen as a strategic necessity in a world shaped by volatile oil prices, geopolitical disruptions and climate concerns.

Yet, there is a difference. Brazil's ethanol drive evolved over decades and gave consumers clear choices at the pump. Flex-fuel vehicles became common and motorists could decide whether to fill up with gasoline, ethanol or any blend. The transition succeeded because policy and consumer behaviour matured together. India, by contrast, has moved with remarkable speed. That speed may prove visionary. But it has also left behind unanswered questions – for



E20 can remain the mainstream fuel. But selected outlets, especially in urban India and highway corridors, could offer pure petrol

owners of vehicles manufactured before the E20 era became the norm.

Trust Deficit

This is where the debate gets uncomfortable. Social media is flooded with videos of motorists claiming that fuel pumps, injectors, rubber hoses and fuel tanks have deteriorated due to E20. Anecdotes are not proof and many such claims draw scepticism. But calling all concerns 'misinformation' would be unwise. Critics point to an unpublished study by the Automotive Research Association of India that reportedly found damage in certain rubber components in vehicles designed only for E10 fuel. According to them, the only option is replacement of affected parts as and when necessary. Whether the findings are published or refined, such concerns explain why owners of older vehicles remain uneasy.

The Government has been consistent, sating E20 does not damage vehicles and that it was introduced only after extensive testing by ARAI and vehicle manufacturers. It adds that ethanol contains less energy than petrol and may lead to some reduction in mileage, but that claims of vehicle damage were "exaggerated". Two-wheelers and cars sold before 2023 were designed for E10 compatibility. Today, their owners are not resisting national policy; they are seeking clarity about the machines they purchased in good faith.

Missing Choice

There is another dimension, in that the current debate is being framed as a contest between supporters and opponents of ethanol. That is the wrong frame. The real issue is whether citizens should have the option to choose the fuel most appropriate for their vehicle. If a motorist owns an E20-ready car, he would be happy to use E20, especially if it is priced lower. Another motorist may own a

decade-old scooter and feel more comfortable using conventional petrol. Why should the second find that option difficult?

Choice is not an obstacle to policy. In fact, it is often the strongest proof of confidence in it. If E20 offers economic, strategic and environmental advantages, most consumers will adopt it voluntarily when pricing and information are transparent.

A sensible middle path is possible. E20 can remain the mainstream fuel. But selected outlets, especially in urban India and highway corridors, could offer pure petrol with clearly-stated ethanol content, or the lack thereof. QR codes at pumps could tell consumers whether their vehicle is E20-compatible. Manufacturers could publish compatibility lists rather than technical footnotes. And long-term data from ARAI, oil firms and automakers could be placed in the public domain instead of circulating through leaks. Such measures would not weaken the ethanol programme. They would strengthen its credibility.

Beyond Blending

There is another inferno simmering, one concerning the sustainability of ethanol itself. India's ethanol plan relies on a diversified feedstock basket, including sugarcane juice, molasses, damaged foodgrain and surplus rice allocated under approved policy, rather than any single source. That diversification is important as it seeks to balance energy security with agricultural economics. Yet, questions are being raised about the long-term implications of scaling up ethanol production when water is becoming a scarce resource. Sugarcane, the backbone of India's ethanol industry, is water-intensive and studies estimate that producing a single litre of ethanol can involve a substantial water footprint. In a nation where many regions grapple with drought and ground-

water depletion, the question deserves discussion, not ideological dismissal.

This is not an argument against ethanol. It is an argument for examining the entire lifecycle of the fuel. If the objective is to reduce dependence on imported crude oil, another must be conserving India's precious groundwater. Public policy should not be forced into choosing one strategic resource over another.

The same approach should guide discussions around higher ethanol blends. As E20 becomes the standard, variants like E25 and beyond are being spoken of. The Government says higher blends are only under evaluation and that no rollout decision has been taken. This presents an opportunity to absorb the lessons of E20 before racing towards the next milestone. For transitions of this magnitude are strongest when they are evolutionary, rather than merely ambitious or blatantly revolutionary.

Trust Matters

An unfortunate fallout of this debate is that it has become polarised. On one side are those who portray ethanol as an unqualified environmental and economic triumph. On the other are those who insist it is slowly damaging their engines. Neither extreme really serves the public interest. For science rarely speaks in absolutes. And engineering certainly does not.

Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari's statement that E20 may marginally reduce fuel efficiency reflects a key principle – that acknowledging a limitation does not weaken a policy, it only strengthens its credibility. His assertion that claims of vehicular damage are exaggerated should encourage authorities to release more data in the public domain. Transparency has an extraordinary ability to silence rumour. This is where India's ethanol story now stands. The country has achieved an ambitious blending target. The next challenge is not logistical. It is psychological. Winning trust is harder than achieving targets.

India's ethanol programme is too important to become trapped in a shouting match between cheerleaders and sceptics. It deserves a mature conversation, one that recognises its strategic value while remaining sensitive to the concerns of motorists who simply want to protect their second-most expensive asset. The debate is no longer about whether ethanol has a place in India's future. It clearly does. The question is whether that future will be built on compulsion or conviction.

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EASTERN
WATCH



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IPS
OFFICER, ADVISER
NATSTRAT, AND A
FORMER NATIONAL
SECURITY ADVISOR
IN MAURITIUS

The renewed prominence of Ziaur Rahman reflects changing political priorities and competing interpretations of Bangladesh's liberation movement and legacy

Shifting Liberation Narrative
India's tribute to Ziaur Rahman comes as the BNP government seeks to reshape Bangladesh's liberation narrative and redefine the country's political memory

In what appears to be a bold move, while paying tribute to former President Ziaur Rahman, who was also the father of Bangladesh's current Prime Minister, Tarique Rahman, the Indian High Commission in Dhaka recalled (May 30) President Zia's radio address of March 1971, which inspired the people on a path of resistance against oppression and led to national liberation. In a post on social media, the Indian High Commission in Bangladesh further elaborated that India stands with the people of Bangladesh in a saga of shared sacrifices and a common journey towards prosperity. The post further said: "As the people of Bangladesh gather today in memory of one of their nation's bravest sons—Shaheed President Ziaur Rahman, Bir Uttam—we recall his famous radio address of March 1971, which electrified the masses, inspired them on a path of resistance against oppression, and led to national liberation. Today, as then, India stands shoulder to shoulder with the people of Bangladesh in a saga of shared sacrifices and a common journey towards the progress and prosperity of both our peoples."

It may be recalled that on May 30, 1981, the then President of Bangladesh, Ziaur Rahman, was assassinated at the Chattogram Circuit House. Bangladesh observed the 45th death anniversary of former President Ziaur Rahman on this day. It is widely believed that Ziaur Rahman, on March 26, 1971, declared Bangladesh's independence in a radio address from the Kalurghat radio station in Chattogram, although this has long been disputed by the opponents of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) and President Ziaur Rahman. It appears that this interpretation has now gained greater acceptance and may soon come to be regarded as a historical reality. Further, India's endorsement that Zia's radio address of March 1971 inspired the people on a path of



India's tribute to former President Ziaur Rahman has added a new dimension to Bangladesh's evolving political discourse

resistance against oppression and led to national liberation, and that he was the first to declare Bangladesh's independence on March 27, 1971, perhaps lends further support to the BNP's longstanding claim.

The death anniversary of Zia, who was also the founder of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), was celebrated with great fanfare this year as his son, Tarique Rahman, is now the Prime Minister. BNP Secretary General and Local Government, Rural Development and Cooperatives Minister Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir said (May 31) that Ziaur Rahman and Bangladesh are inseparable, adding that the country's Liberation War began with Zia's declaration of independence and that he later played a pivotal role in rebuilding the nation. Through Ziaur Rahman's declaration, the Liberation War of Bangladesh began, and through that war, Bangladesh emerged before the world as a new state. Fakhrul made these remarks while presiding over a discussion at the Krishibid Institution Bangladesh (KIB) auditorium in Farmgate, Dhaka, marking the 45th death anniversary of BNP founder

and former President Ziaur Rahman. Describing Ziaur Rahman's emergence as a remarkable and extraordinary phenomenon, Fakhrul further claimed that the BNP founder appeared before the nation at every critical moment in history. He also termed it a miraculous occurrence that Zia emerged at every crucial juncture. In 1971, when the people were confused and directionless, Major Zia's call awakened the nation, he claimed. Again, in 1975, when the country found itself in a similar situation, Zia once again awakened the nation and united it, as Fakhrul consistently maintained.

Further, the BNP Secretary General and Local Government, Rural Development and Cooperatives Minister, Fakhrul, also highlighted various initiatives undertaken under Ziaur Rahman's leadership, including post-war reconstruction, the promotion of Bangladeshi nationalism, the formation of what he described as a cabinet comprising the country's most capable individuals, the introduction of multi-party democracy, the fostering of national unity, and various economic reforms. Refer-

ring to the ongoing political discussions on reforms, Fakhrul averred that the BNP itself had introduced major reforms in the country. He said that Ziaur Rahman introduced multi-party democracy after a one-party system of governance and carried out fundamental changes in the country's political structure. According to Fakhrul, Zia ensured the freedom of the media, judicial independence, and the establishment of democratic institutions.

Among those who attended the meeting were BNP Standing Committee members Abdul Moyeen Khan, Amir Khasru Mahmud Chowdhury, Selima Rahman and Professor AZM Zahid Hossain; Senior Joint Secretary General Ruhul Kabir Rizvi; Dhaka North BNP Convener Aminul Haque; Dhaka South BNP Member Secretary Tanvir Ahmed Robin; Jatiyatabadi Swachhasebak Dal President SM Jilani; Jatiyatabadi Jubo Dal General Secretary Nurul Islam Moni; and Jatiyatabadi Chhatra Dal President Rakibul Islam Rakib, all of whom spoke at the event. Noted economist Professor Mahbub Ullah, University Grants Commission Chairman Professor Mamun Ahmed, National University Pro-Vice Chancellor Professor Md Lutfor Rahman, and Bangladesh Open University Pro-Vice Chancellor Professor Dil Rowshan Zinnat Ara Nazneen also addressed the gathering, highlighting different aspects of Ziaur Rahman's life and his perceived contributions.

On his part, speaking on his father's death anniversary, Prime Minister Tarique Rahman warned party leaders and activists that a difficult and important period lies ahead and called for their support in implementing the party's election manifesto to make the government successful. The Prime Minister also said that the loss would not be for any individual alone but for the country and future generations, and called for everyone to work together to build the country in the manner Shaheed

Zia had envisioned and to move it forward along the path he had charted. Tarique Rahman stated that Ziaur Rahman wanted to make Bangladesh self-reliant by gradually developing every sector of the country, and that the BNP's election manifesto reflects that vision. Tarique Rahman claimed that the current administration is a political government with a clear ideology, vision and manifesto. He also said that the BNP had presented its plans to the people before the election, and that voters had endorsed those plans by giving the party a two-thirds majority. Referring to Ziaur Rahman's contributions, he said many of the policies outlined in the manifesto were inspired by the former President's initiatives. Tarique Rahman added that the manifesto includes programmes similar to Zia's canal excavation project, as well as plans to expand education, promote industrialisation and create employment opportunities. Utilising the occasion of the death anniversary, the Prime Minister urged party leaders and activists to take a fresh pledge to fulfil Ziaur Rahman's vision and ideals.

It would appear from the profiles of the discussants that they were individuals of high academic stature, and the inclusion of intellectuals to speak on Ziaur Rahman on his death anniversary indicates a clear attempt to revive and reinforce his legacy, particularly now that the BNP is in power. Objectively, it would seem that if the firm entrenchment of Ziaur Rahman's place in history continues to receive such endorsement, it is likely to gradually diminish the historical prominence of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, who has traditionally occupied a more dominant position in Bangladesh's national narrative, perhaps owing to the long tenure of Sheikh Hasina's rule. Moreover, India's endorsement could further lend credibility to that evolving narrative.

Views expressed are personal

CHINA SLAMS US, UK, 12 OTHER NATIONS

EU, 14 nations reaffirm South China Sea claims illegal under 2016 ruling

BEIJING: China on Sunday denounced the US, the UK and 12 other nations for reaffirming their support for the 2016 international tribunal ruling invalidating its claims over South China Sea, saying that they blatantly endorsed the illegal “award.”

China’s sovereignty and relevant rights and interests in the South China Sea were established in the long course of history, and are solidly grounded in the law, a Chinese Foreign Ministry statement said.

“China’s activities in the South China Sea are fully legitimate, lawful and beyond reproach. China’s rights in the South China Sea can by no means be denied by the makeshift ‘arbitral tribunal,’” it said.

“In rendering the ‘award,’ the ‘arbitral tribunal’ exceeded its authority and abused its



Chinese President Xi Jinping

jurisdiction. The ‘award’ is naturally illegal, null and void, and has no binding force,” it said, adding that “China neither accepts nor recognises the ‘award,’ and opposes and will never accept any claim or action arising from it.”

A five-judge tribunal appointed by the Permanent

Court of Arbitration (PCA), based in The Hague, adjudicating on the petition filed by the Philippines in 2016, struck down Beijing’s claims of historic rights to resources within the sea areas falling within the ‘nine-dash line’.

China claims most of the South China Sea. The Phil-

Highlights

» The Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan have counterclaims

» Other signatories to the statement included the US allies such as Japan, Australia and Britain

» The Tribunal concluded that China’s claims were incompatible with the exclusive economic zones provided for in UNCLOS

the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

Earlier on Sunday, a 14-nation coalition led by the United States and the Philippines issued a joint statement reaffirming their “unwavering commitment” to a rules-based, free and open Indo-Pacific, marking a decade since an international tribunal at The Hague invalidated most of Beijing’s South China Sea claims.

Other signatories to the statement included the US allies such as Japan, Australia and Britain.

The 14-nation statement described the 2016 award decision as a “significant milestone” that was “final, legally binding, and definitive”. It added that there was no legal basis for Beijing’s sweeping maritime claims, including those based on historic rights. AGENCIES

Ukrainian PM steps down as Prez Zelenskyy announces govt reshuffle

KYIV: Ukrainian Prime Minister Yulia Svyrydenko stepped down on Sunday as President Volodymyr Zelenskyy announced fresh changes to Ukraine’s government, saying he had offered a new and important position to the former premier.

Zelenskyy, who has remained in office under martial law because wartime elections are prohibited, has periodically reshuffled his government in an effort to bring fresh momentum to his administration.

Svyrydenko, who has served as Ukraine’s economy minister, was named prime minister in July 2025 at the age of 39 after playing a lead role in securing a mineral agreement between Ukraine and the United States, seen as an important way of tying U.S. interests to Ukraine’s security.

In a statement on social media, Svyrydenko said she was “proud to have had the honor of leading the government during one of the most difficult periods in Ukraine’s



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

modern history.” She also said she had discussed “next steps” with Zelenskyy, but did not provide further details.

“I remain ready to serve the Ukrainian state and carry out every task aimed at strengthening Ukraine’s position, defending our national interests and bringing a just peace closer,” she said.

Zelenskyy announced her resignation in a post saying that Ukraine was “changing its political strategy.” He also

said he had offered Svyrydenko the opportunity to lead “a new, important area” in Ukraine’s relations with a key international partner.

“Each priority area of foreign policy will be assigned to a specific person with substantial experience who is capable of implementing what we agree on at the leaders’ level and what the Ukrainian people expect,” Zelenskyy said, describing the impending reshuffle. AGENCIES

New Syrian parliament holds first session



DAMASCUS: Syria’s new parliament convened for the first time on Sunday, 19 months after rebels led by President Ahmed al-Sharaa toppled Bashar al-Assad, a milestone in the country’s political transition despite the chamber’s current limited powers.

Sharaa, in a speech at parliament in Damascus, told lawmakers to “make this council a model of responsibility and competence” and described it as “a platform for truth and justice.”

“Syria is writing a glorious history that reflects its heroism, and we face the responsibility of building both the nation and the individual,” he said.

The parliament has been seen as a test of Sharaa’s pledge to build an inclusive new order in Syria, which was run as a police state by the Assad family for decades, with a legislative chamber that was seen as a rubber stamp.

Under the country’s interim governing arrangements, two-thirds of the members of the 210-seat chamber were chosen last year by regional electoral colleges, while Sharaa named the

“SYRIA IS WRITING A GLORIOUS HISTORY THAT REFLECTS ITS HEROISM, AND WE FACE THE RESPONSIBILITY OF BUILDING BOTH THE NATION AND THE INDIVIDUAL”

remaining third on July 1.

Officials have said this system was necessary because years of war had left millions displaced and made it impossible to rely on accurate population records or voter rolls.

Critics say it gave the executive branch extensive control over the selection process.

Sharaa has said he supports holding general elections once infrastructure and documentation allow.

A temporary constitutional declaration introduced in 2025 granted parliament limited authorities, and there is no requirement for the government to win a parliamentary vote of confidence. AGENCIES

US Senator Lindsey Graham, close Trump ally, dies at 71

WASHINGTON: US Republican Senator Lindsey Graham, one of President Donald Trump’s closest allies and an influential voice on American foreign policy, has died after what his office described as a “brief and sudden illness”. He was 71.

Graham, who represented South Carolina in the Senate for more than two decades, was among the Republican Party’s most outspoken supporters of Ukraine in its war against Russia and a leading advocate of tougher sanctions on Moscow.

Despite a bitter rivalry with Trump during the 2016 Republican presidential campaign, he went on to become one of his closest political allies.

Graham was a vocal critic of India’s purchases of Russian oil amid the Ukraine war and repeatedly called for sanctions against countries, including India, buying Russian energy.

Earlier this year, Graham said Trump had “greenlit” a bipartisan legislation he had worked on for months. AGENCIES

At least 109 terrorists killed in anti-terror onslaught in Balochistan

ISLAMABAD: Over 105 terrorists have been killed in a week in the restive Balochistan province of Pakistan, 71 of them since July 7 when Operation Shaban was launched, defence officials said on Sunday.

Balochistan, which has been facing unrest for about two decades, has in recent months seen an uptick in the violence by the ethnic Baloch rebels and Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan militants who target the security forces in the region.

Official sources said that 109 terrorists have been killed since July 5, including 71 killed in Operation Shaban. AGENCIES

Vietnam boat tragedy: Bodies of 15 Indian tourists to be flown home

HANOI: The bodies of the 15 Indian tourists who were killed in a boat accident off Vietnam’s Phu Quoc Island have been sent to Ho Chi Minh City from where they will be transported to India, the Indian mission said on Sunday.

The Indian Embassy in Hanoi also said that 16 of the 17 rescued Indian tourists are on their way back home. One, who is in critical condition, is hospitalised in Phu Quoc.

The 15 were killed when a speedboat carrying 32 tourists from India and four local crew members capsized near Hon May Rut Ngoai off Phu Quoc Island on Saturday. All others were rescued.

“The mortal remains of the 15 Indian nationals who tragically passed away in yesterday’s boat accident are being transported to Ho Chi Minh City and will reach there by this evening,” the embassy said in a



Rescue personnel carry out operations after a boat carrying Indian tourists capsized near Hon May Rut Ngoai off Phu Quoc Island AP/PTI

post on X.

“After completion of formalities at Ho Chi Minh the mortal remains would be transported to India at the earliest,” it said.

The embassy further said its teams were closely coordinating with the Vietnamese authorities, who have assured

all assistance for the earliest transportation of the mortal remains to India.

Of the 15 victims, 10 were from Tamil Nadu, three from Andhra Pradesh and two were from Kerala. Two of the deceased were women, according to a list shared by the embassy. AGENCIES

Israeli fire in Gaza kills 5, including a girl child, say health officials

DEIR AL-BALAH: Israeli fire in Gaza on Sunday killed at least five Palestinians, including a 9-year-old girl, and wounded others, according to local health officials.

A drone strike on a blacksmith shop in Gaza City’s Sabra neighborhood killed at least four Palestinians and wounded another, according to officials at Shifa hospital, where the casualties were taken.

The Israeli military acknowledged striking the area, saying it targeted “terrorist infrastructure,” without elaborating. Palestinians received an evacuation order from the military following the first strikes. Roughly an hour later, intense airstrikes targeted the same blacksmith shop.

Also on Sunday, Israeli gunfire killed 9-year-old Tala Abu Matar in a displacement camp in central Gaza, according to officials at the Health Ministry. The Israeli military said it was unaware of such an incident. Israeli strikes have lessened considerably since a ceasefire took effect on Oct 10, but they continue almost daily.

Israel’s military says it targets Hamas and other militants, often asserting they were planning attacks. The strikes have also killed many civilians. At least 1,098 Palestinians, including at least 260 children, have been killed since the ceasefire, according to Gaza’s Health Ministry. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed in that time.

The Oct 7, 2023, attack by Hamas-led militants that sparked the war killed some 1,200 people in Israel and saw 251 others taken hostage. AGENCIES

Typhoon Bavi weakens but still brings strong winds, rain to China

BEIJING: Typhoon Bavi weakened Sunday to a tropical storm hours after making landfall in eastern China’s Zhejiang province, but was still bringing days of strong winds and heavy rain to parts of China.

Its intensity continued to weaken as it moved northwest across eastern China into the province of Anhui as of Sunday afternoon, according to China’s national weather centre.

Strong winds and heavy rain are expected to impact many eastern and north-eastern Chinese cities

Key Points

- » Strong winds and heavy rain are expected to impact many eastern and northeastern Chinese cities
- » In Yueqing, over 1,300 trees were toppled
- » In Zhejiang province, more than 2.2 million people were evacuated

adding that heavy to torrential rain was recorded Sunday afternoon in provinces including Anhui.

In Zhejiang province, more than 2.2 million people were evacuated due to Bavi, according to state media.

Shanghai evacuated over 290,000 people from at-risk areas, while Fujian province evacuated more than 180,000 people.

In the coastal city of Yueqing in Zhejiang province, more than 1,300 trees were toppled, including at least 700 uprooted, according to state broadcaster CCTV. AGENCIES

Hypertension no longer confined to old age

Experts said one of the biggest concerns is that high blood pressure rarely causes symptoms

NEW DELHI: Young adults in India are increasingly developing high blood pressure, a condition once considered more prevalent in the middle and old ages, with cardiologists attributing the trend to sedentary lifestyles, obesity, chronic stress and unhealthy diets.

They warned that many remain unaware of the problem until serious complications such as a heart attack, stroke or kidney disease occur.

The NFHS-6 (2023-24) data shows that 19.4 per cent of women and 22.1 per cent of men (aged over 15) have elevated blood pressure or are on medication for hypertension in India, with urban areas reporting significantly higher rates than rural regions.

Experts said one of the biggest concerns is that high blood pressure rarely causes symptoms until complications develop.

“Most young patients feel completely healthy. They often discover elevated blood pressure during a routine check-up, before surgery, or after a cardiac emergency,” said Dr Rahul Chandola, chairman of the Institute of Heart Lungs



Representational Image

Diseases Research Centre and founder of AI-based healthcare technology platform iLive Connect. A single reading in a hospital is just a snapshot; what matters is how blood pressure behaves over weeks and months in daily life, he said.

“Connected home monitoring devices that share readings directly with a doctor’s team allow us to catch masked hypertension, adjust treatment early, and prevent complications before they occur,” Dr Chandola said.

He said adults, especially those with obesity, diabetes, a family history of hypertension or heart disease, should monitor their blood pressure at home using validated digital devices. The Indian Council

of Medical Research (ICMR)-INDIAB study has shown that hypertension affects more than one in four Indian adults, with a large proportion of cases remaining undiagnosed. The study identified obesity, diabetes, urban living, physical inactivity and excessive salt intake as major risk factors.

Dr Rajiv Narang, head of the Department of Cardiology at AIIMS, Delhi, said that 10 years ago, hypertension in people below 40 was relatively uncommon in routine cardiology practice. “Today, it is something we encounter almost every day,” he said.

Many young professionals have prolonged sitting hours, consume highly processed foods, sleep poorly and remain

The doctors stressed that lifestyle modification remains the cornerstone of preventing hypertension, particularly among younger adults

under constant stress.

“These factors together are accelerating vascular ageing much earlier than expected,” Dr Narang said.

“People often believe hypertension is an illness of old age. That misconception needs to change. Blood pressure should become as routinely monitored as body weight or blood sugar. Early diagnosis and sustained lifestyle changes can prevent decades of cardiovascular complications,” he said.

Dr Chandola highlighted that untreated hypertension silently damages the arteries supplying the heart, brain and kidneys, substantially increasing the risk of premature cardiovascular disease.

The doctors stressed that

lifestyle modification remains the cornerstone of preventing hypertension, particularly among younger adults.

Regular physical activity of at least 150 minutes every week, maintaining a healthy body weight, reducing dietary salt, increasing consumption of fruits and vegetables, avoiding tobacco, limiting alcohol intake, managing stress and ensuring adequate sleep can significantly reduce blood pressure and lower long-term cardiovascular risk, Dr Narender Singh Jhahhria, Head of the Department of Cardiothoracic and Vascular Surgery (CTVS) at Dr RML Hospital and ABVIMS said. He also pointed to the growing evidence linking excessive salt consumption with hypertension in India.

An ongoing ICMR-led initiative has found that average salt intake in both urban and rural populations exceeds the World Health Organisation’s recommended limit of five grams per day, prompting researchers to evaluate low-sodium salt substitutes as a strategy to reduce hypertension and cardiovascular disease, Dr Jhahhria said. AGENCIES

World Briefs

BANGLADESH REPORTS 44 DEATHS DUE TO FLOODS; CAPITAL DHAKA DELUGED

DHAKA: At least 44 people have died in flood and landslide incidents in a week, officials said Sunday even as rivers remained above danger level leading to displacement of over 2.5 lakh families across Bangladesh. Overnight torrential rains – 76 mm from 12 midnight till 6 am – inundated several areas and paralysed life in capital Dhaka even as the government deployed army troops alongside navy and air force personnel to carry out relief operations in seven worst-hit districts along with local humanitarian agencies. “Since July 5, officially 44 flood related deaths were recorded until Saturday evening. We estimate that some 2,67,000 families have been affected so far,” a Disaster Management Ministry spokesman said.

INDIAN-ORIGIN MAN JAILED FOR OVER 6 YEARS AFTER FATAL HIT-AND-RUN IN UK

LONDON: An Indian-origin man has been jailed after being convicted of causing the death of a pedestrian in a high-speed hit-and-run in east London, the UK’s Metropolitan Police said. Mayan Hirani, 26, was sentenced to six years and nine months’ imprisonment at Woolwich Crown Court in London on Friday, after being found guilty of causing a man’s death by dangerous driving and then failing to stop at the scene. The Met Police said that officers traced the Range Rover involved in the collision in March 2024 to a garage in east London through CCTV and “extensive investigative work”.

EVEN AS MOSCOW'S OIL REVENUES SLIP

India's Russian crude imports surge 34% to record high in June

India bought Russian crude worth EUR 4.5 billion in June, accounting for 83 per cent of its total Russian fossil fuel imports of EUR 5.5 billion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's imports of Russian crude oil surged to a record high in June, rising 34 per cent from the previous month despite a decline in Russia's overall oil export revenues, according to a report by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA).

India bought Russian crude worth EUR 4.5 billion in June, accounting for 83 per cent of its total Russian fossil fuel imports of EUR 5.5 billion, making it the second-largest buyer of Russian hydrocarbons after China, the report said.

The sharp increase came as India's overall crude imports rose 5.4 per cent month-on-month, with Russian supplies to key refineries posting steep gains. Deliveries to Reliance Industries' Jamnagar refinery jumped 150 per cent from May, while imports at Indian Oil Corp's Paradip refinery rose 126 per cent. BPCL's Kochi refinery and Nayara Energy's Vadinar refinery recorded increases of 83 per cent and 45 per cent, respectively, CREA said.

The surge in Indian purchases helped lift Russia's crude



export volumes by 14 per cent in June, even as its crude oil export revenues fell 8 per cent month-on-month to EUR 348 million a day due to lower prices. Overall, Russian fossil fuel export revenues declined 1 per cent to EUR 734 million per day despite a 7 per cent rise in export volumes, the report added.

"India was the second-largest buyer of Russian fossil fuels in June 2026, importing a total of EUR 5.5 billion of Russian hydrocarbons. Crude oil constituted 83 per cent of India's purchases, totalling EUR 4.5 billion. Oil products (EUR 488

million) and coal (EUR 444 million) constituted the remainder of their monthly Russian imports," CREA said.

India continued to play a key role in global trade flows of refined fuels produced from Russian crude. Refineries in India, Türkiye, Brunei and Georgia exported oil products worth EUR 814 million to countries that have imposed sanctions on Russia in June, including the European Union, Australia and the United States. An estimated EUR 369 million of those exports were refined from Russian crude, it added.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Sharp hike came as India's overall crude imports rose 5.4% month-on-month
- » Deliveries to Reliance's Jamnagar refinery rose 150% from May
- » Imports at IOC's Paradip refinery & BPCL's Kochi refinery rose 126% & 83%, respectively

allowing imports of diesel and jet fuel refined from Russian crude oil. The cargo, valued at approximately EUR 63 million, was unloaded at the ports of Thames Haven and the Isle of Grain," it said.

Jamnagar refineries are owned and operated by Reliance Industries Ltd.

"Exports to the US originated at the Jamnagar refinery in India, the SOCAR-owned STAR refinery in Türkiye, and the Tupras Izmit refinery as well. In the prior three months, 60 per cent of the Tupras Izmit refinery's crude oil feedstock and 27 per cent of the Jamnagar refinery's feedstock came from Russia," it said.

China remained Russia's largest fossil fuel customer in June, accounting for EUR 7.3 billion of purchases, while India ranked second with EUR 5.5 billion, CREA said.

The report also highlighted the continued reliance of Russian oil exports on the so-called "shadow fleet", with 54 per cent of Russia's seaborne oil transported by sanctioned shadow tankers in June, while another 43 per cent was carried by G7-insured or owned vessels.



Meanwhile, SIP contributions touched a record Rs 31,781 crore in June, taking SIP assets under management to Rs 17.70 lakh crore

Rs 11,568 crore, accounting for 66 per cent of total SIP inflows, the report said.

Equity-oriented investment strategies received Rs 1,097 crore in June, rising 68 per cent from Rs 652 crore in the previous month. Cumulative inflows into the category since October 2024 stood at Rs 4,938 crore, contributing 28 per cent of overall SIP inflows.

The report said cumulative inflows into SIPs have reached Rs 17,407 crore since October 2024, indicating growing investor acceptance of the newly introduced investment vehicle.

The broader mutual fund industry also witnessed sustained investor participation during June. The total mutual fund AUM rose to Rs 82.2 lakh crore, while active equity and

hybrid funds together attracted net inflows of around Rs 36,000 crore.

Active equity mutual funds recorded gross inflows of Rs 67,601 crore in June, compared to Rs 57,604 crore in May, while net inflows into the category stood at Rs 28,973 crore.

Hybrid funds, excluding arbitrage funds, received net inflows of Rs 7,163 crore during the month compared to Rs 4,862 crore in May.

Gold ETFs (exchange traded funds) also rebounded sharply, posting net inflows of Rs 3,443 crore in June after witnessing net outflows of Rs 725 crore in the previous month.

Meanwhile, systematic investment plan (SIP) contributions touched a record Rs 31,781 crore in June, taking SIP assets under management to Rs 17.70 lakh crore.

Outstanding SIP accounts increased to 10.52 crore, supported by strong net new registrations, reflecting continued retail participation despite market volatility.

This also highlights the maturity of investors. Rather than reacting emotionally, they are increasingly using phases of improved market momentum to continue their long-term wealth creation journey, Santosh Joseph, CEO, Germinate Investor Services, said.

"The resilience in SIP flows and the recovery in equity inflows are reassuring indicators for the mutual fund industry and reflect sustained confidence in India's long-term growth story," he added.

Goyal to visit Spain, Belgium, Finland to boost trade



NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will visit Spain, Belgium and Finland from July 13-17 to explore opportunities for enhancing trade and investment ties with the three European nations, the Commerce Ministry said.

A delegation of Indian companies from sectors including advanced manufacturing, clean energy, digital technologies, healthcare, food processing, gems and jewellery and design will accompany the minister.

In Spain, Goyal will attend a business roundtable with industry leaders to discuss cooperation in sectors such as automobiles, renewable energy, railways, artificial intelligence, semiconductors and tourism.

During his Belgium visit, he will hold CEO-level meetings and co-chair the India-EU Trade and Technology Council (TTC) Ministerial Meeting with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and MoS for IT Jitin Prasada. In Finland, Goyal will engage with businesses on digitalisation, clean energy, advanced manufacturing and the circular economy.

AGENCIES

NSE listing to 'complete the troika', unlock value & governance upgrade

NEW DELHI: A potential NSE listing is positioned as the final step to "complete the trioka" of India's market infrastructure, with forward-looking benefits expected in transparency, valuation discovery and global index inclusion, according to a research report by Jefferies.

The report argued that an IPO would be a near-term catalyst. "NSE listing will bring greater transparency, better governance and price discovery for India's largest exchange", it notes, adding that it will also "pave the way for MSCI and FTSE inclusion of NSE as an investable entity" once regulatory hurdles are cleared.

The brokerage expects the listing to trigger re-rating across capital market peers. "We expect the listing to act as a benchmark for valuation of other exchanges and market



infrastructure institutions", the report says, with potential spillovers for depositories, clearing corporations and data vendors.

The timing is tied to resolution of legacy issues. The report flagged that "once the co-location case and other regulatory matters are fully settled, the path for IPO will open up".

Until then, it expects NSE to continue strengthening compliance and disclosure norms to meet public-market standards.

Beyond governance, the

report highlighted the strategic rationale. It described NSE, CDSL and BSE as the three pillars of India's market structure -- the "trioka". Listing of NSE will complete the trioka and provide investors a full set of listed market infra plays. That completeness is seen as critical for domestic and foreign investors seeking direct exposure to India's trading volumes and derivatives growth.

Financially, the report expects listing proceeds and the public float to improve NSE's flexibility. "Capital raised can be deployed toward technology upgrades, international expansion and new product lines like GIFT City and data services". It also sees the move pushing the exchange toward global best practices on board independence and segment reporting.

ANI

NSE outlines post-listing growth plans, to focus on new products, data monetisation & partnerships

MUMBAI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has outlined an ambitious post-listing growth strategy focused on new product launches, global expansion, data monetisation and technology-led automation, as India's largest exchange seeks to capitalise on long-term growth in the country's capital markets.

According to NSE's July 2026 investor roadshow presentation, the exchange's next phase of growth will be driven by business diversification, technology investments, international partnerships and creation of new revenue streams.

The exchange plans to "drive market innovation and business diversification"

and automate large markets through the launch of new products.

It also aims to expand opportunities in its data business by leveraging its market data ecosystem.

The exchange said it will pursue global partnerships and strengthen its presence at the Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City) International Financial Services Centre as a "gateway to the world". The exchange also plans to build a strategic off-shore presence to tap global opportunities.

Alongside international expansion, NSE will continue investing in technology infrastructure and modernisation

while supporting capital formation in India by attracting new issuers and investors across asset classes.

The exchange said its growth plans are supported by favourable structural trends, including economic expansion, rising financialisation of household savings, increasing digital adoption and a growing investor base.

The presentation highlighted that financial assets accounted for 47 per cent of gross household savings in FY24, up from 40 per cent in FY12.

Unique PAN registrations on the exchange platform have increased from 40 million in FY21 to 129 million in FY26,

while mutual fund assets under management have more than doubled, supported by higher systematic investment plan (SIP) inflows.

NSE said its vertically integrated business model across listing, trading, clearing and settlement, and data and analytics businesses positions it well to benefit from these trends.

The exchange also highlighted strong network effects, with increasing participation, higher trading volumes and continuous innovation reinforcing growth across its businesses. The investor presentation is part of NSE's outreach ahead of its proposed public listing.

AGENCIES

Govt plans to open missile production to pvt cos



NEW DELHI: India is preparing to allow private companies to manufacture missiles in a major overhaul of its defence production policy, according to a *Hindustan Times* report. The move is aimed at expanding domestic production capacity amid rising demand from the armed forces and growing export opportunities.

The report said Indonesia has shown interest in acquiring the Defence Research and Development Organisation's (DRDO) Astra missile, prompting the government to accelerate plans to involve private industry in missile production.

While private firms already participate in sectors such as aircraft, drones, artillery and naval platforms, missile manufacturing has largely remained the preserve of state-run defence entities. Opening the sector would mark one of the

most significant reforms in India's defence manufacturing landscape.

According to the report, the Defence Ministry is preparing to issue a Request for Proposal (RFP) inviting private Indian companies to manufacture the Astra Mark 2 beyond-visual-range (BVR) air-to-air missile.

The decision has been driven by increasing demand from both the Indian military and friendly foreign countries, which Bharat Dynamics Ltd is currently unable to fully meet, the report said.

Developed by the DRDO, the Astra Mark 2 has a strike range of 180-200 km and was designed to counter China's PL-15E long-range air-to-air missile supplied to Pakistan before Operation Sindoor. The missile is slated for integration with Tejas Mark 1A, MiG-29, Su-30 MKI and Rafale Marine fighter aircraft.

The report added that the Pralay tactical ballistic missile could be the next missile system opened to private players for development and manufacturing. With a range of around 500 km, the two-stage missile can travel at six times the speed of sound and forms part of India's Integrated Rocket Forces alongside the Long-Range Land Attack Cruise Missile (LRLACM), next-generation BrahMos and the

extended-range Pinaka rocket system.

According to the report, the government's push reflects lessons from Operation Sindoor and the recent Iran-US conflict, both of which underscored the strategic importance of precision missiles and air defence systems.

India is also strengthening its air defence architecture. The report said India and Israel are jointly developing a long-range surface-to-air missile for naval warships, while the country is building a multi-layered anti-missile and anti-drone network.

The fifth S-400 air defence system is expected to arrive in November, and the government is planning to procure five additional S-400 units from Russia, protected by the Pantsir air defence system against drone and rocket attacks.

AGENCIES

'India-UK FTA to benefit exporters, MSMEs, professionals from July 15'

MUMBAI: Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Sunday announced that the India-UK FTA will allow all Indian exports to enter the British market duty-free from July 15, benefiting farmers, fishermen, MSMEs, and domestic industries.

Speaking to reporters here, Goyal said the trade pact also features a Double Contribution Convention (DCC) that exempts Indian professionals working in the UK for up to five years from British social security contributions for securing their retirement savings.

"The India-UK trade agreement not only covers merchandise, goods and services but

also benefits thousands of Indians working in the UK. From July 15, any item exported from India to the UK will attract zero import duty," he said.

He said the agreement also includes a DDC, under which Indian professionals working in the UK for up to five years will not have to contribute to the British social security system.

"Earlier, nearly 25 per cent of their (Indian professionals') salaries used to go towards the UK government's social security contributions. Now, that amount will be deposited in their provident fund accounts in India, earning 8.25 per cent annual interest. It will remain tax-free and help secure their

retirement savings," he said.

Goyal said the agreement would create new opportunities for Indian professionals while strengthening trade and economic ties between the two countries.

He further stated he was leaving on a four-country tour with a business delegation to strengthen India's trade partnerships.

The minister said he would attend the India-EU Trade and Technology Council meeting in Brussels on July 14 and 15 to resolve pending issues and advance technology cooperation.

The technology transfer would benefit India's growth, he said.

PTI

ONGC drills second well in Ladakh, for first pilot geothermal power plant

NEW DELHI: State-run Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) has completed drilling its second geothermal well in Ladakh's Puga Valley, marking another step towards developing India's first pilot geothermal power plant.

The company's research and development arm, ONGC Energy Centre, drilled the well to a depth of 1,000 metres at an altitude of over 14,000 feet in about a month, improving on the timeline and cost of its first geothermal drilling campaign, ONGC said. The latest well builds on the success of ONGC's first geothermal well in Puga, which produced steam at



temperatures above the boiling point of water, demonstrating the area's geothermal resource potential, the company said.

ONGC said the second well would support the development of India's first 1-megawatt electric (MWe) pilot geothermal power plant and could pave the way for commercial exploitation of geothermal energy in

the country. The project's next phase includes plans to set up a 1-megawatt electric (MWe) pilot geothermal power plant and the longer-term development of geothermal resources to provide reliable baseload electricity for Ladakh.

The Puga geothermal field, located in eastern Ladakh, is considered India's most promising geothermal resource. Geothermal energy harnesses heat from beneath the earth's surface to generate electricity and provide heating, and offers a source of round-the-clock, low-carbon power, unlike solar and wind energy, whose output depends on weather conditions.

PTI

Banks' treasury gains to improve in April-June FY27

However, the impact of these gains on overall profitability is likely to remain limited

CLOSER LOOK

- » 'The yields softened in Q1 FY27 after having risen sharply towards the end of January-March qtr FY26'
- » The benchmark 10-year government bond yield fell 38 basis points during the April-June quarter, declining from 7.133 per cent at the start of April to 6.750 per cent by the end of June

profitability may be only partial, as fair value changes on investments classified under the Available for Sale (AFS) category are recognised directly in net worth," said Sachin Sachdeva, Vice President and Sector Head, Financial Sector

Ratings at ICRA.

The benchmark 10-year government bond yield fell 38 basis points during the April-June quarter, declining from 7.133 per cent at the start of April to 6.750 per cent by the end of June. This followed a sharp

rise of 45 basis points in the Jan-March quarter, when yields climbed from 6.582 per cent to 7.035 per cent amid higher oil prices & inflation concerns triggered by West Asia crisis.

The reversal in bond yields was supported by easing geopolitical tensions, policy measures by the RBI and the government, and increased foreign investment flows into Indian bonds.

Analysts said the extent of treasury income will depend on the composition of banks' investment portfolios across categories. While some fair value changes are reflected in profit and loss accounts, those under

AFS classification are adjusted directly in net worth, limiting their impact on reported earnings. Brokerage reports estimate banks could post 9-14 per cent year-on-year profit growth in the June quarter, supported by healthy credit growth and lower provisioning costs.

Meanwhile, deposit growth and net interest margin expansion are expected to remain challenging. Bank credit growth stood at 17.7 per cent year-on-year as of July 15, 2026, against 12 per cent deposit growth, pushing the system credit-deposit ratio to around 83.4 per cent.

AGENCIES

TARGET 2026 CONCLUSION

India & Canada conclude third round talks on CEPA

NEW DELHI: India and Canada have concluded the third round of negotiations for the India-Canada Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in Ottawa, with "positive progress" across tracks.

According to a post by the Department of Commerce, the negotiations were held in Ottawa from July 6-10 2026.

The two sides reaffirmed their commitment to wrap up talks this year.

"India and Canada concluded the third Round of negotiations for the India-Canada Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in Ottawa from 6-10 July 2026," the Department of Commerce said in a post on X.

"The discussions witnessed positive progress across multiple negotiating tracks, reaffirming the shared commitment of both countries to conclude the negotiations in 2026, in line with the vision of the leaders," it added.

The latest round marks progress in trade engagement between the two countries. A CEPA is expected to go beyond the traditional goods-focused FTA to cover services, investment, government procurement, digital trade, and sustainable development.

Officials from both sides



'The discussions witnessed positive progress across multiple negotiating tracks, reaffirming the shared commitment of both countries to conclude the negotiations in 2026, in line with the vision of the leaders'

discussed market access for goods, rules of origin, trade in services, and cooperation in key sectors including critical minerals, clean technology, agriculture, and pharmaceuticals. Canada is a major source of potash, pulses and energy for India, while India exports pharmaceuticals, textiles, engineering goods and IT services to Canada.

The push to conclude CEPA in 2026 aligns with both governments' focus on diversifying

trade partnerships amid global supply chain shifts.

For India, a deal with Canada would add to its recent trade agreements with the UAE, Australia and the EFTA bloc. For Canada, India is its 10th largest trading partner and a key market in the Indo-Pacific strategy.

While details of specific chapters agreed in the third round were not disclosed, the statement indicates momentum on technical work ahead

KEY POINTS

» For India, a deal with Canada would add to its recent trade agreements with the UAE, Australia and the EFTA bloc

» For Canada, India is its 10th largest trading partner and a key market in the Indo-Pacific strategy

» While details of specific chapters agreed in the third round were not disclosed, statement indicates momentum on technical work ahead of ministerial engagement later this year

of ministerial-level engagement later this year.

Both countries have said they aim to conclude the negotiations in 2026, after which legal vetting and ratification processes will follow before the agreement comes into force.

With two-way goods trade at around CAD \$10 billion in recent years, a concluded CEPA is expected to provide a formal framework to expand bilateral commerce and investment flows.

ANI

Mcap of four of top-10 most valued companies jumps ₹92,995.48 crore

HDFC Bank and Bharti Airtel emerged as the biggest gainers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of four of the top-10 most valued firms jumped Rs 92,995.48 crore last week, with HDFC Bank and Bharti Airtel emerging as the biggest gainers.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex declined 194.52 points, or 0.25 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dipped 63.95 points, or 0.26 per cent.

"Markets ended the week marginally lower, snapping a four-week winning streak amid renewed geopolitical tensions in West Asia and a sharp spike in crude oil prices," Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Markets started the week on a positive note, supported by easing crude prices, encouraging Q1 business updates, improving monsoon progress, and broad-based buying, he said.

However, sentiment weakened during mid-week following escalating Iran-US tensions, triggering a sharp sell-off before benchmark indices recovered a significant part of the losses over the final two sessions, Mishra added.

The gainers from the top-10 pack were Reliance Industries (RIL), HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), while

Top 10 (BSE)	Market Cap	Gain/Loss over July 3, 2026
₹ crore	As on July 10, 2026	
RIL	17,71,206.33	▲ 6,224.97
HDFC Bank	12,69,454.42	▲ 35,808.09
Bharti Airtel	11,98,774.22	▲ 34,896.92
ICICI Bank	10,05,379.71	▼ -6,315.32
SBI	9,56,430.44	▼ -3,461.48
TCS	7,48,600.40	▼ -8,574.87
Bajaj Finance	6,35,327.78	▼ -7,813.58
LIC	5,60,205.05	▲ 16,065.50
Larsen & Toubro	5,42,938.40	▼ -11,040.23
Hind Unilever	504,997.65	▼ -12,088.65

Source: BSE

KBK Infographics

ICICI Bank, State Bank of India (SBI), Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro (L&T) and Hindustan Unilever (HUL) faced a combined erosion of Rs 49,294.13 crore from their valuation.

HDFC Bank's market valuation surged Rs 35,808.09 crore to Rs 12,69,454.42 crore, the most among the top-10 firms.

The valuation of Bharti Airtel jumped Rs 34,896.92 crore to Rs 11,98,774.22 crore.

LIC added Rs 16,065.5

crore, taking its valuation to Rs 5,60,205.05 crore, while the valuation of Reliance Industries climbed Rs 6,224.97 crore to Rs 17,71,206.33 crore.

However, the market capitalisation (mcap) of Hindustan Unilever dropped by Rs 12,088.65 crore to Rs 5,04,997.65 crore.

Larsen & Toubro's valuation declined by Rs 11,040.23 crore to Rs 5,42,938.40 crore.

The mcap of TCS diminished by Rs 8,574.87 crore to Rs 7,48,600.40 crore, and that

HIGHLIGHTS

» Last week, the BSE Sensex declined 194.52 points, or 0.25% and NSE Nifty dipped 63.95 points, or 0.26%

» 'Markets ended the week marginally lower, snapping a four-week winning streak amid renewed geopolitical tensions in West Asia & sharp spike in oil prices'

» Reliance Industries retained the title of the most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, SBI, TCS, Bajaj Finance, LIC, L&T & HUL

of Bajaj Finance eroded by Rs 7,813.58 crore to Rs 6,35,327.78 crore.

ICICI Bank's mcap edged lower by Rs 6,315.32 crore to Rs 10,05,379.71 crore, while the valuation of State Bank of India dipped by Rs 3,461.48 crore to Rs 9,56,430.44 crore.

Reliance Industries retained the title of the most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, LIC, Larsen & Toubro and Hindustan Unilever.

'Gold, silver may remain volatile on US-Iran tensions'

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver are expected to remain volatile with a corrective bias in the coming week as investors assess the latest flare-up in the US-Iran conflict, movements in crude oil prices and inflation data that could reshape expectations for global interest rates, analysts said.

Fresh hostilities in West Asia have once again put markets on edge.

Analysts said any further escalation in the conflict could drive crude oil prices higher, revive inflation concerns and strengthen safe-haven assets such as the US dollar and Treasury yields, limiting the upside for precious metals.

On the domestic front, MCX gold futures for August delivery fell Rs 3,900, or 2.65 per cent, during the week to close at Rs 1.43 lakh per 10 grams.

Silver for the September contract also plunged Rs 14,746, or 6.2 per cent, to Rs 2.22 lakh per kilogram.

In the international markets, Comex gold futures slipped \$12, or 0.3 per cent, to end at \$4,113.7 per ounce in New York, while silver fell 1.5 per cent, to \$60.16 per ounce.

Analysts said market participants will closely monitor a series of key US economic indicators, including retail sales, housing data and weekly jobless claims, for further clues on the Federal Reserve's policy path.

PTI

FPIs reverse 4-month selling trend, infuse ₹15,157 crore in Indian equities in July

Prior to selling spree, FPIs had invested Rs 22,615 cr in Indian equities in Feb

NEW DELHI: After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, investing over Rs 15,157 crore so far this month, supported by improving domestic macroeconomic indicators, a stable rupee and better global risk sentiment.

The latest inflow follows net outflows of Rs 49,340 crore in June, Rs 32,963 crore in May, Rs 60,847 crore in April and a massive Rs 1.17 lakh crore in March, according to the CDSL data.

Prior to the selling spree, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) had invested Rs 22,615 crore in Indian equities in February.

Despite July's turnaround, foreign investors have pulled out a net Rs 2.6 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026,

The latest inflow follows net outflows of Rs 49,340 cr in June, Rs 32,963 cr in May, Rs 60,847 cr in April & massive Rs 1.17 lakh cr in March, according to the CDSL data

exceeding the Rs 1.66 lakh crore withdrawn in the same period of 2025.

According to Himanshu Srivastava, Principal Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India, the reversal in July reflects improv-

ing global risk appetite, easing concerns over energy prices following the de-escalation of geopolitical tensions earlier this month, and renewed confidence in India's macroeconomic fundamentals.

VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, said improving domestic macroeconomic conditions and the rupee's stability have played a key role in attracting foreign inflows.

He added that weakness in the semiconductor trade and FPIs turning sellers in markets such as South Korea also redirected flows towards India.

Srivastava noted that after a period of market consolidation, valuations have become more reasonable, prompting

foreign investors to selectively increase exposure to high-quality Indian firms.

He, however, cautioned that while July's sharp reversal is encouraging, the sustainability of FPI inflows will depend on global developments and the resilience of India's domestic growth story.

Meanwhile, debt continues to attract growing foreign interest. FPIs invested Rs 6,625 crore in debt securities through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) and Rs 3,228 crore through the general route during July.

Vijayakumar said the government's changes to the taxation of debt investments have made Indian debt more attractive to FPIs while contributing to the rupee stability.

PTI

'Geopolitical situation, earnings, oil prices to drive mkts this week'

NEW DELHI: The US-Iran geopolitical conflict, quarterly earnings announcements, and crude oil price movement will influence investor sentiments in domestic equities, according to analysts. Besides, monsoon trend, inflation data and trading activity of foreign investors will also be closely watched by market participants, they added.

"Domestically, investors will closely monitor June CPI inflation, WPI inflation, and the latest foreign exchange reserves," Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

The Q1 FY27 earnings season will gather pace, with management commentary expected to play a pivotal role in shaping sectoral trends and earnings



expectations, he said.

Globally, developments surrounding the Iran-US conflict and their impact on crude oil prices will remain key monitorables, Mishra added.

After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, investing over Rs 15,157 crore so far this month, supported by improving domestic

macroeconomic indicators, a stable rupee and better global risk sentiment.

"This week will see earnings from several companies, including HCL Technologies, Tech Mahindra, Union Bank, Federal Bank," Santosh Meena, Head of Research at Swastika Investmart Ltd, said.

On the macroeconomic front, inflation data will remain an important trigger, he said.

India's Consumer Price Index inflation will be released on Monday, followed by the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) on Tuesday, Meena said, adding that investors will also closely monitor the progress of monsoon, given its implications for rural demand and inflation.

PTI

NEW DELHI: The Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) has invited applications from eligible provident fund (PF) trusts under its newly launched Amnesty Scheme, 2026, offering a one-time opportunity to regularise their exemption status.

The six-month scheme, notified on June 29, is open to employers, stakeholders and eligible establishments operating exempted PF trusts recognised under the I-T Act, 1961, but lacking a formal exemption notification under the Employees' Provident Fund & Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952.

The Labour Ministry said the initiative follows changes introduced through the Finance Act, 2026, which align the Income Tax framework for recognised provident funds with



Recognition under the I-T Act will be available only to PFs that have secured exemption under Section 17 of the EPF Act

the provisions of the EPF Act and the Code on Social Security, 2020. Going forward, recognition under the I-Tax Act

will be available only to provident funds that have secured exemption under Section 17 of the EPF Act.

Under the scheme, eligible establishments can obtain retrospective regularisation of their trusts under Section 17 of the EPF Act and Section 143 of the Social Security Code.

The amnesty covers establishments that have already begun complying as unexempted entities, those planning prospective compliance, as well as organisations seeking to continue operating as exempted establishments under the Social Security Code.

Among the key benefits, eligible trusts will receive retrospective exemption and trust recognition from the date of their inception up to the prescribed cut-off date. They will

also receive relaxation from certain requirements under the Social Security Code, including minimum employee strength and corpus size norms, while the three-year prior compliance requirement will be deemed fulfilled. The ministry said pending assessments related to dues, damages and interest will be withdrawn, provided members have received contributions and interest equal to or higher than statutory rates. Past finalised orders will also be treated as void.

Eligible establishments can submit applications to the Centre through the concerned EPFO regional office. They may also send an expression of interest via email to rc.exemption@epfindia.gov.in, while regional offices will assist applicants with processing and guidance.

AGENCIES

SBI Funds Management to spearhead ₹10,100 crore IPO wave on Dalal Street this week

The three IPOs—SBI Funds Management, Alpine Texworld and SME player Millworks Technologies—will remain open for bidding from July 14-16

NEW DELHI: India's primary market is set for another action-packed week, with three initial public offerings (IPOs) worth more than Rs 10,100 crore opening for subscription on July 14, led by the Rs 9,812.91-crore public issue of SBI Funds Management.

The three IPOs—SBI Funds Management, Alpine Texworld and SME player Millworks Technologies—will remain open for bidding until July 16.

The much-awaited SBI Funds Management IPO, backed by State Bank of India and French asset manager Amundi, is entirely an offer-

for-sale (OFS) of 17.09 crore equity shares priced at Rs 545-574 a piece. The issue size was reduced from Rs 11,692.9 crore after a pre-IPO placement involving 30 investors.

Under the OFS, SBI will sell 9.95 crore shares, equivalent to a 4.89 per cent stake, while Amundi will offload 7.14 crore shares, or 3.51 per cent. As the issue is entirely an OFS, the company will not receive any proceeds, with the entire amount going to the selling shareholders. At the upper end of the price band, SBI Funds Management is valued at about Rs 1.17 lakh crore.



Gujarat-based textile manufacturer Alpine Texworld will launch the second mainboard IPO, aiming to raise Rs 126.25 crore through a fresh issue of 1.2 crore equity shares. The company has fixed a price band

CLOSER LOOK

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of Rs 100-105 per share, valuing it at Rs 401.5 crore.

The proceeds will be used to establish a new weaving unit to expand grey fabric production capacity, repay borrowings and meet general corporate

requirements.

In the SME segment, Bengaluru-based precision engineering firm Millworks Technologies plans to raise Rs 160.3 crore through a fresh issue of 48.44 lakh equity

shares at a price band of Rs 315-331 per share. The company intends to utilise the funds for purchasing plant and machinery, meeting working capital requirements and other general corporate purposes.

The latest offerings will further boost fundraising in the primary market. So far this year, 30 mainboard IPOs have collectively raised Rs 24,404 crore. With SBI Funds Management and Alpine Texworld, the total amount mobilised through 32 mainboard issues will rise to Rs 34,343 crore.

In the SME segment, 90 companies have raised Rs

3,861 crore in 2026. With the addition of Millworks Technologies, the cumulative fundraising will increase to Rs 4,022 crore.

Meanwhile, the Rs 742-crore IPO of power transmission and distribution equipment maker Laser Power & Infra will close for subscription on July 13 after achieving full subscription. SME issues of Devson Catalyst and Happy Steels will also close the same day.

Devson Catalyst, which manufactures catalysts, adsorbents and ceramic balls for industrial applications, had

been subscribed 27.35 times after the first two days of bidding, while automotive components manufacturer Happy Steels received 2.95 times subscription.

Laser Power & Infra, Devson Catalyst and Happy Steels are all scheduled to list on the stock exchanges on July 16.

According to market observers, all three companies continue to command double-digit grey market premiums, with Laser Power & Infra quoting at about 17 per cent, Devson Catalyst at around 38 per cent and Happy Steels at nearly 21 per cent.

AGENCIES

‘YOU CAN’T SIT HERE AND CRACK ROLES THERE’

Actress Disha Patani revealed how Indian actors ‘have to be present’ in Hollywood

Bollywood actress Disha Patani is all set to mark her highly anticipated international breakthrough with the upcoming supernatural action thriller ‘Holiguards Saga: The Portal of Force’. Directed by Academy Award winner Kevin Spacey, marking his fifth project since his legal acquittal in the UK, the film features Disha in a pivotal role alongside a powerhouse global cast including Dolph Lundgren, Tyrese Gibson, Brianna Hildebrand and Eric Roberts.

In a recent interview, the ‘Welcome to the Jungle’ star candidly shed light on what it truly takes to make it in Hollywood, emphasising that actors can’t simply sit in India and expect to crack global roles without navigating the complex technicalities of international auditions, talent representation and visa logistics. Disha also fondly recalled her filming experience with Spacey, praising his unique actor-centric directing style and collaborative morning workshops.



Speaking to ‘Variety India’, Disha said, “Kevin Spacey is amazing. Being an actor, he understands his actors. He is one of the finest actors in the world. He gives his actors a lot of space to experiment. He’d tell us to draw from our own experiences. We’d be encouraged to think of questions like ‘How would you react to a situation like this?’, ‘Would you cry?’, ‘What would you feel?’ or ‘How would you emote?’ Every morning, he’d sit with us and take us through the scene. I found that really special. I don’t think I did that with any of the creators in the past. It’s

also like taking some responsibility for understanding the character and delivering it.” The actress also spoke about her journey into Hollywood, shedding light on how factors like representation, accessibility, auditions and logistical aspects such as visas play a significant role in the process. She said, “A lot depends on accessibility. The West focuses heavily on audition templates. You have to audition for things. It depends on how accessible that is for you and who you are signed with. Destiny also plays a role.” AGENCIES

The ‘Welcome to the Jungle’ star is set to star next in ‘Holiguards Saga: The Portal of Force’



Chris Kattan to feature in horror film ‘TRASH QUEEN’

The details about the role of the actor are kept under wraps

LOS ANGELES: Hollywood actor and comedian Chris Kattan is set to return to the horror genre with his next film, ‘Trash Queen’.

Kattan is known for his roles in projects such as “A Night at the Roxbury” and “The Middle”. He last appeared in a horror film in the 1999 cult classic ‘House on Haunted Hill’, where he essayed the role of Watson Pritchett.

The actor will join the previously announced cast, which includes the names of Matty Cardarople, Lynn Lowry, Jonathan Stoddard, Kevin Keppy, Emily Tullock, Bonne-Vejou Dorrell and others, according to the entertainment news outlet ‘Deadline’.

The details about the film’s plot and the role of the actor are kept under wraps. The film is directed



Kattan said he is excited to return to the horror genre with the film

by Gabrielle Rosson and is produced under ‘Joan of Art LLC’ and ‘Trash Queen LLC’.

Kattan said he is excited to return to the horror genre with the film. “House on Haunted Hill” has remained such a special film for me, and horror fans have always been incredibly loyal.

“Trash Queen” has a fun, twisted energy that immediately drew me in and I can’t wait for audiences to see what we’ve been cooking,” the actor told the outlet.

The actor is currently on his stand-up comedy tour, with which he is performing in cities across the United States. PFI

THE 20-YEAR DEBT

Matt says he wants to work with Shekhar Kapur

The Indian filmmaker lauded ‘The Odyssey’ actor’s ‘emotional depth’

Hours after ‘The Odyssey’ star Matt Damon revealed his ‘20-year debt’ to work with Shekhar Kapur, the veteran Indian filmmaker expressed his desire to collaborate with the actor, 24 years after a missed opportunity to work together. Kapur lauded Damon’s ‘emotional depth’ and agreed that it’s now time for them to collaborate, since they couldn’t back in 2002.

“I don’t think there is a filmmaker in the world who wouldn’t give their right arm to work with an actor who has as much emotional depth as Matt Damon. Who can ever forget his famous scene with Robin Williams, ‘It’s not your fault’, in ‘Good Will Hunting’. I must have watched it over 1000 times and been moved to tears each time,” Kapur told NDTV.

Damon broke through in Hol-



Kapur expressed his desire to collaborate with Damon, 24 years after a missed opportunity to work together

lywood with his performance as the titular character Will Hunting in Gus Van Sant’s ‘Good Will Hunting’ (1997). Also starring late legendary actor Robin Williams and Damon’s longtime friend and collaborator Ben Affleck, ‘Good Will Hunting’ fetched both Damon and Affleck

their maiden Academy Awards for ‘Best Original Screenplay’.

“Events move between the past, present and the future... while time is created in our imagination. So, it’s time Matt and I finally collaborate,” said Shekhar. The filmmaker’s wish came right after Damon revealed

his unfulfilled wish to work with Shekhar back in the early 2000s, in response to him being asked which Indian filmmaker he’d like to collaborate with now, at the India press conference of Christopher Nolan’s upcoming action-adventure fantasy epic ‘The Odyssey’ in Mumbai on Saturday.

“I remember that when we were starting out, everyone wanted to collaborate with Shekhar Kapur. I remember when I couldn’t do ‘The Four Feathers’ for some reason; I was really upset about that,” Matt Damon said at the press conference.

The actor added, “I think I was signed up for a ‘Bourne’ movie. So, I guess, he has always been on my list and I would like to have another go. That’s like a 20-year-old little debt I’ve been carrying around in my pocket.” AGENCIES

HEMA MALINI RECOUNTS HER 60-YEAR JOURNEY IN FILMS

The ‘Sholay’ and ‘Seeta Aur Geeta’ actress said she feels ‘blessed’ and ‘proud’ of her journey

MUMBAI: Veteran actress Hema Malini, who is celebrating 60 years in Indian cinema, feels ‘blessed’ and ‘proud’ of her journey, crediting filmmakers, co-stars, technicians and her family for their unwavering support.

The actress marked the landmark moment with ‘Hema Malini - Live in Concert: Celebrating the Dream Girl’s Diamond Jubilee - 60 Glorious Years in Cinema’. Held at Mumbai’s Shanmukhananda Hall on Friday evening, the concert saw a 15-piece live orchestra celebrating milestones from her film career through songs.

Malini, the star of movies such as ‘Sholay’, ‘Seeta Aur Geeta’, ‘Satte Pe Satta’, ‘Khushboo’, ‘Naseeb’ and ‘Baghban’, said she is grateful to the public for showering their love and support over the years.

“I’m thankful to my mother; she stood

by me. I believe mothers play an important role in the life and career of their children. My family was with me and that’s why I was able to grow,” the 77-year-old actress said.

She added, “I’m extremely happy and proud to be part of this beautiful film industry, which has given birth to so many stars in the past and present. In the few decades that I’ve spent in the industry, I’ve done nearly 200 films and so many memorable songs to my credit and worked with so many directors and actors.”

Malini, who has acted in over 200 films in a six-decade career, also directed two films, Shah Rukh Khan starrer ‘Dil Aashna Hai’ (1992) and ‘Tell Me O Kkhuda’ (2011) featuring her daughter Esha Deol. “The film industry is so vast and beautiful that it gives an opportunity to everyone. The only thing is you’ve got to be talented and dedicated and then you will reach the top,” she added.

Asked how she felt seeing stills and posters of her hit films, Malini quipped that they reminded her she was once young and beautiful. “I looked so nice and I was just so happy to



see myself. When you’re young, you’re always beautiful. But the way cinematographers used to shoot my scenes and those of other female actors back then was incredible. They were so passionate about their work and filmed every scene with great interest and care,” she said. She recalled working with

She marked the landmark moment with ‘Hema Malini - Live in Concert: Celebrating the Dream Girl’s Diamond Jubilee - 60 Glorious Years in Cinema’

cinematographers like K Vaidyanathan and Kamal Bose on films such as ‘Seeta Aur Geeta’ and ‘Dharmatma’. “They all used to do beautiful photography, which I don’t see much these days because it’s a digital world now and things are different. But their dedication was outstanding,” she said.

Malini also acknowledged the contributions of costume designers and makeup artists. “They worked with so much love and dedication in all my films. It is

because of their contribution that I looked the way I did on screen,” she said. When asked if Deepika Padukone can do a biopic on her, Malini instantly replied in the affirmative. “If she wants, she can do it. Anybody can do it and anyone can do it (film on me). Deepika is a beautiful, talented girl.”

The evening saw performances by singers Sudesh Bhosle, Suresh Wadkar, Padmini Kolhapure, Shabbir Kumar, Anu Malik, Anup Jalota, Kavita Krishnamurti, Vijeta Pandit and

Purnima Shrestha, who recreated some of Malini’s popular songs, including ‘Meri Makhna Meri Soniya’, ‘Hori Khele Raghuvendra’ and ‘Ek Na Ek Din Ye Kahani Banegi’.

Malini expressed gratitude to the singers for performing at the concert. “I feel fortunate. I’m thankful to them,” she said, adding that the craze for the 1970s and 1980s remains strong around the world.

Some of Malini’s industry friends and colleagues, including Madhoo, Poonam Dhillon, Rakesh Roshan, Shatrughan Sinha, Jeetendra, Ramesh Sippy, Kiran Juneja, Babul Supriyo, Sanjeev Gupta and others, attended the charity musical concert.

Malini thanked her co-stars for their presence. PFI

